



Thezeraine.

Luna Maltseva



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Thezeraine.

The most frightful challenge is to
live hoping for a better tomorrow

Preamble

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In 2059, Thezeraine adopted the slogan “Authern vivae,” which roughly translates to: “Enable life.”

§ Réveillée

Opening her diary, “Split with the Darkness,” she located a free page, titling it “Whatever us awaits tomorrow,” dated it 11/05, and composed:

“The sunset rose above the mist
To make the beauty that we have
Live on if just a moment more
Before it all becomes pitch black.”

Though she enjoyed the piece, she sank back into her chair, becoming immersed in thought. Slightly shaking her head, she sat up and began:

“The beginning and the end are concealed in impenetrable darkness.

“If time is nothing more than a learned illusion, there exists neither a past nor a future. To us, there is only the ever-lasting present—then, now, soon—which are all but a part of a single moment.

“In the old days, the stillness that comes with a non-relativistic point-of-reference could perhaps be exaggerated into being called a ‘limbo’—perhaps even promoted to ‘hell’ for its inescapable single action frame.” Allowing fear to sprinkle in, she wrote, “Yet at times even the present comes outside of our grasp. In closing one’s eyes to fall asleep, one only realizes that they had dozed off because they had woken up. If the waking-up part was suspended indefinitely, with no point-of-reference there would remain no notion of sleep—rendering the whole experience imperceptible

to any naturally-existing prism of interpretation.

“What falls outside the beginning and the end”—heavily underlining the word *end*—“could not be described in terms of ‘limbos.’ With no reference frame, these ‘voids’ have no dimensions in them—they lack both the geospatial and the chronological aspects of it and are dominated by ‘nothing’. Not vacuum, for though vacuum seems the definition of ‘nothing,’ our vacuumcraft are comfortable traversing the intragalactic medium. Vacuum is habitable—‘nothing’ is not. ‘Nothing’ is utterly barebone—it never began anywhere and will never end, and of it none will ever have any recollection.

“Death is not scary. If everything that’ll ever come of it is ‘nothing,’ then there is, from a reckless viewpoint, nothing to worry about.

“The scary part is being woken up.”



I. Off The Deep End

1-North Sta.

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“It is surprising to what lengths our consciousness goes to keep our dreams alive,” she smiled, receiving a smile in return; she said, reaching out: “and oh-how-I-wish it didn’t.”

Iris opened her eyes with difficulty, faced contemplating whether she was now experiencing yet another half-nightmare; she tried to cognizantly transform the dream—if it was a dream—only to be greeted by the immutable dark of the maglev’s cabin. Giving up, she laid still, staring blankly into the void surrounding her.

The fluorescent cabin lights of the ASP VacTrain maglev began powering up, painting the tubular cabin in a dim and rough blue hue, followed by a gentle two-phased tone, signaling the impending arrival at Theoderau’s intercontinental maglev station, 1-North, in just under five minutes. It has been a couple of hours since the maglev departed from A-1’s Spaceport’s Echo Terminal for Theoderau—the only city on A-1 boasting a stable population, approximately two hundred thousand people, notwithstanding the vieuxtritolo-poisoned biosphere.

Terminal Echo was the only commercial spaceport on Theoderau, primarily serving as a transfer to

and from AZ-0's Geostationary Intrastellar, and was located 5'600 kilometres south-east off the city, at the equatorial west of the Atlantic ocean. Despite being an overcapacity transfer from AZ-0 Geostellar via Beyon's Hopper, the maglev was almost fully booked—recent events at blame—with some two hundred passengers on board. Now, the alighting was to happen before dawn—the sun not to rise for another hour—permitting both residents and visitors alike ample time to admire the incandescent night-time urban paysage.

With the lights on, the passengers turned abuzz, going through their accouterments, connecting via neural ports to the maglev to sign arrival forms, diving into the cyberspace to tend to urgent personal and professional affairs, keeping tabs on the rampantly escalating “situation;” their tetranol-powered Aegis inductive shields lighting up—pulsating emerald-green under strain, further actuating the cabin lights—in order to upkeep spatial equilibrium while the maglev was proactively exuding momentum: the atmosphere of urgency and anxiety palpable——midst of all that, Ms. Feverenn continued to lie still, observing with a sense of pleasantry the sublime orchestration of the mundane, *oh-so-expertly* performed. She was a young woman, fairly tall, espresso hair and eyes, lightly augmented with NSynapse's advanced neural cortex and Apex limb reinforcements, primarily for recon, quite slender – more so as of late; under different circumstances, she would perhaps be remarked by others for fairness, sharpness, and tenderness. The cabin lights were approaching blinding brightness, slathering the cabin in minor blue. She sighed and pushed herself onto her back, now staring into the beaming void above her.

Why me? she spun at herself for the millionth time in the last two months, idly tracing patterns in the

ceiling with her eyes. She reached for the bumpy white plastic texture of the ceiling, drawing her fingers across it, longing to feel some kind of sensation. Not satisfied with the resulting bleakness, she lowered her hand with a deep sigh. *Inappropriate as it is to envy others, I can't help but...*, she feebly pronounced, tears filling her eyes at the thought, *can't help but envy her*.

The maglev was perceptibly losing momentum, an item falling over somewhere in the cabin every once in a while, even with everyone's shields having fully lit lime hexagonal outlines, water vapor trailing off them—the signature color of “Powerline Energy’s” “tetranol,” a weaker and much less toxic version of “nitritol,” being broken up. Iris slowly sat up on her bunk, now facing the wall in front of her. She threw a negligent glance around the populous cabin. Bunk beds, six rows—samey porous white grainy ceilings used everywhere in transportation, lifeless smooth arsenic panel-walls to mix with the whites, accentuated with yellow ladders, navy blue with sparse-colored-dots satin beddings, curtains, and linen floor serving as the accent color—*trifling* to her taste. Of the people she could see, most were slightly disheveled by the lengthy trip, currently on standby, ready to detrain the moment the maglev docked, meanwhile mindlessly sauntering in the cyberspace, devoid of expression.

Iris wiped her tears and silently chuckled, disconcerted. *What wouldn't I give away to lose the ability to think*, she voiced to herself, observing the rest; *or remember*. Overcome with the unbearable weight of grief, she let out a quiet sigh, destined for the abyss. *Or even both*, she concluded.

In search of a way to throw off her thoughts, she, too, connected to the cyberspace using Axioneer’s “Aurum” neural network-interface, in her case under the

justification of “staying in the loop” with “the situation.” There were more rallies in the Raydeucar region and adjacent cities on A-2—Meretau and Panemor being notable; a tetranol-powered “Nail”-ammunition “Swift” power-propulsion rifle (C-178S:N) used by one of the “Equinox” (pro-independence) “protestors,” killing six people, injuring more. “Abhorred by Raydeucar’s leadership,” *yeah right, sure*, she commented to herself. The violent nature of the act galvanized arguments in Thezeraine’s Imperial Council, effectively polarizing the body on all levels—both branches and factions (internally!)—into two clashing camps, arguing over how to deal with the situation: diplomatically or by force – *Nothing unites us like a common threat, huh?* – with a popular projection stating that the ordeal had the potential to blow up into a “grave conflict” if the tension was to continue to rise. *Everything’s going to hell as of late*, she thought—hardly anything nouveau, though: Raydeucar has always been a brewingland of a region for separatist revolutionary aspirations (*not sans reason*), though quite rarely succeeding ones.

All the lights in the cabin went on. Another chime.

Politics, politics, politics, she wrapped up, pulling away from the tab specifically reserved for her beloved *The Chronicle*—the only paper she read along with *Catalyst*, a monthly journal, both forever open therein. No further updates in her professional inbox, in spite of the growing unease at Theuneurau, capital of the Empire Thezeraine; rather surprising, given the nature of her employment, even with recent controversy. Alas, there were numerous untended messages in her personal inbox, which, not having the mental capacity to go through, she postponed replying to until another time, one that will happen *under different circumstances, under a lighter and less feeble mind*, she justified to herself.

Pulling out of the cyberspace, she caught the final chime—the maglev’s intercom stating arrival at 1-North, Theoderau, (*The City of Thought*, as she affectionately referred to it) with six minutes to detrain. All other passengers grabbed their bags from their compartments and poured out into neighboring cabins, to the nearest exit. Gathering her thoughts and strength, Iris properly sat up, pulled back and tied her hair, opened the compartment door in the wall with a click, sent in the prefilled form, latched onto her beloved structured bag, and slid down from her bunk onto the floor. The cabin was, by this time, nearing being emptied. Having made her bunk and pat it twice as a goodbye, she wistfully began to progress to the front exit, following others in their footsteps. She went through the first screen door and into the adjacent dining cabin—with the all-too-familiar arsenic walls, navy blue and impeccably white sofas and chairs, mramor tables and bar surface, over which so much vanity-talk had been spilled to the pizzazz of light jazz. Not giving the decor much more of her attention, Iris passed through the salon and by a person rushing to finish their meal—as if he had something critical to attend—as she passed through another screen door. The last seating cabin accumulated a sizable queue, slowly pouring out of the maglev, which had depressurized moments prior. She looked over the seating, through the transparent infotainment displays—currently serving as windows—onto the platform. The outer cover of the maglev was actively condensing water from the air into thick white mist, partially obscuring the view. Aligning with her expectations, despite it being early morning, the station was unusually crowded—not just with those arriving for the city, but also those gravely intent on departing it.

Moving in line with the queue, Iris exited the

maglev, stepping onto the wet-from-light-rain southern platform of 1-North, into Theoderau's humid and chilly night air, light rain causing the chilled metallic envelope of the maglev to hiss. The night was pitch black—a storm was raging outside the LES, the Large Enveloping Shield: an Aegis-designed gargantuan nitritol- and vieuxtritol-powered Photonic-Hardmatter (PHm) half-sphere enveloping Theoderau, circling it by its offshore – the only thing standing between the citizens within and the vieuxtritol-affected ecosystem without. Tonight the LES itself was not its typical homogenous hexagonal blue pattern in the sky—it had elongated yellow patches cruising through the pulsating royal blue hexagonal sea of the shield towards the cap—a byproduct of it being run at higher power and being stimulated by the storm.

The platform hoisted a sense of worry in the air which so often comes in times of uncertainty—a worry that materialized in anxious whispers. On the platform, there were faces in various states of despair, folks fearmongering and gossiping, all in the seeming pretence of indifference and annoyance. It might have been the first time Iris had ever seen Starboard—1-North's cozy lounge & cafeteria, with downward angled reflective glass walls looking out towards the trench-like tracks, the maglev in its reflection mesmerizing; its interior playfully mixing orange with white and blue lighting—so filled with livelihood. Clusters of people forming in and around booths, heated discussions rapturing out by the bar and adjacent tables, the jingle of the music hardly discernable amidst all the discourse – every last person was weighing in. To her surprise, even the giftshop aisle was operating. Iris attributed that to the rest of the city being dormant in the face of the night – with megatowers, such as Skyline and Atlas Rise, being only semi-operational, thus making

Starboard the only on-the-table dining option so deep into the night, which, despite not having eaten in 9 hours, she decided to pass on, wanting to neither huddle and socialize nor skip on sleep, postponing her repast for solitary brunch in her own apartment.

Slowly walking along the roughened blue-pearl granite platform to the overpass connecting the station with Theoderau via Altaire blvd., Iris insensitively observed the “flocks” all over the station, their movements, their interactions, their dialogues; as well as the reflections of the LES and station illumination-lights glittering on the floor, the walls, the wet bushes on walls and boxes—ignoring the content of the citylights—and even the maglev itself. The halo produced by the towering city center—under different circumstances by all means breathtaking—especially Experté, a stratoscraper in the shape of a split blade, Theoderau’s widely-recognized signature landmark and thus mascot—went unnoticed, filtered out by Iris, who was instead reliving the painful moments of days not so long in the past. There was rain, there were people, and though their presence was noticed, it was not acknowledged. Several minutes passed in this deep dissociative contemplation; the maglev had begun to repressurize and would soon silently take off, carrying its new payload.

Having hiked the rubber-padded overpass, Iris turned around to find the maglev missing. With no one to really say goodbye to, she turned to Theoderau and made her way across the harrowed bridge connecting 1-North Station to Altaire blvd., an arterial road spanning the city north-to-south—one out of five total such roads. The streetcar stop on the left side of Altaire, placed to receive incoming streetcars from the roundabout on the far end of the overpass, was

filled to the brim with people, their luggage piled into precarious mountains—the reduced nighttime service not being of much help. Iris shot a glance to both sides of the boulevard, checking for incoming streetcars, appreciating her beloved jungle-like dense forest hill in the middle of the roundabout to her right. Confirming the absence of incoming trams, she crossed tracks to the other side of the edgelit arch bridge, making sure to mind the curb. Turning to Theoderau, the view of the glowing citytowers from 1-North had always been astonishing, even more so now that it was night-time. The city center was a collection of flat and somewhat slender scrapers, stepping and stacked to allow for their terrifying altitude, at times invoking active PHm support even in the absence of wind, panelled and dimly-lit-up, arranged like an inverted paraboloid; the scrapers growing in size as they neared the centre, with Experté inching over all others. Theoderau's city center (and everything else) differed from other major cities in Thezeraine: it attempted to capture and maintain the architectural zeitgeist from 13 centuries ago, hardly a dozen years before the city, and the world, collapsed. Its architecture is what made Theoderau feel like home to Iris—the view of which was most excellent from the top of her apartment building in the “Lower Southern” district; that view rivaled only by the view in front of her right now.

The recollection of that view made her nauseous: her head feeling heavy. Even though she reduced her pace, she caught herself midfall, and having regained balance, halted, middle of the bridge, scrutinizing glowing Theoderau with a cold-blooded stare. The ashen sidewalk of the bridge felt bleak and forlorn to Iris' judgement, with seemingly not a soul in sight: the world empty, ravaged, and ruined by uncertainty.

Iris scoffed. Surfacing at last from the boiling tar of her thoughts, with two heavy swift steps, she steered herself towards the edge of the bridge, slamming her hands against the railing, breathing shakily and trembling from powerlessness. She let herself collapse onto the deck of the sidewalk, her structured bag bouncing away from her. Cursing inwards, she allowed tears to flow unobstructed, quietly sobbing; *of all places*, she thought. Trying to calm herself down, she inhaled the cold air, freezing her lungs, observing the edging lights, examining how light bled onto other surfaces. “Beautiful can, these things be,” she uttered with difficulty—difficulty which, she would be lying if she said she didn’t enjoy. She pulled out a pillcase, popping alprazolam, putting up her back against the parapet, she looked above the horizon, through the LES, past the en’s storm outside, trying to focus on feeling the rain as it fell on her skin.

“Is everything alright, dear?” a woman came up to her, kneeling down.

Iris replied with a trembling voice, looking up, “Yeah, everything is alright, just, not having the best of nights.”

The woman inquired, “Would you like to share? I’m Parker.” She seemed marginally older than her, in minimalist darkened beige clothes, blonde hair and emerald eyes, shielded from the rain by a dark travel umbrella, with no obvious implants—*civilian, chances are*.

Iris stood up and picked up her structured bag, greeting her, “Hi, Parker. Iris. Just living through a very rough patch in my life. It’s... work, had a,” she paused temporarily, sighing, “close friend die on me.”

With sorrow notes, Parker said, “That is awful, I am so sorry you had to go through that, Iris. Can I be of any

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help to you?”

Iris smiled, “No, thank you, Parker, for being so kind.”

“I know, from personal experience, that at times like these, loneliness can be excruciating.” Iris slightly nodded. “Would you like to join me on my way downtown?”

“No, no,” Iris returned politely, “Thank you for the offer; I’m going to be fine.”

Weighing it, Parker returned, “Okay,” she smiled, “it’s your call. Would you like a hug?”

Iris hesitantly agreed.

Having parted with her transient acquaintance, she turned to the sea, looking out towards the continental Aethelon. Sighing deeply, she slammed her fist on the handrail, reveling in the sharp burn of pain. Waves from the ocean were breaking on the rocky shore. The elevation of the bridge exceeded fifteen meters in the middle. Without a word, her left hand swiftly reached for the Aegis shield fixed to her right lapel, powering it off, and her right hand mirrored the action: both of her shields now black reflective surfaces, with a hardly discernible underlying gray outline to the shields’ hexagonal pattern. She leant on the parapet and appeared to intensely examine the raging ocean below, hearing loud thuds for every pulse of her ramping up heart: every sound so much louder and clearer. Slowly letting the cold breeze fill her lungs, she let the latch of her structured bag slide off her shoulder; the bag hit the bridge’s deck behind her with a metal twang moments after—a twang which, to her surprise, she did not hear. She closed her eyes, took a deep breath, and straightened out, moving closer to the parapet. With another deep breath she set out her hands as supports and leaned on

them.

“Iris!” a familiar voice seemed to cheerfully call her up, coming from the northern side of the bridge.

Snapped out with terror, Iris slightly backed away from the edge, turning her head to the source of the voice, frightened; her vision somehow blurry and head ringing. “Orion?” Iris inquired, turning to the figure, confusedly, somewhat disappointed, returning to partially lean on the parapet.

“What is the-sunshine-of-Theuneurau, doing here at this hour?” Orion cordially inquired, walking up to her.

She smiled, innerly glad to see a familiar face after so long. He was not much taller than her, though about one and a half times her age; part of Hover’s engineering lead, specializing in external system integration—similarly lightly augmented, with implants designed to allow for precise movement; close in shade hair, blue eyes. Iris knew him from a fairly young age, admiring him not so much for his technical skills as for his knowing a way around things. Now, as they stood on the bridge, while her smile had not yet dissolved, she had become visibly immersed in thought, borderline dissociating.

Orion came up to the parapet, and initiated, glancing towards her, “You haven’t been replying to messages lately. Are you doing okay?” Iris maintained her fading façade, slightly lowering her eyes to greet the ocean. Orion examined her saddened countenance. After a small pause, Orion walked around her, picking up her structured bag from behind her, jokingly commenting, “Not worried of a tetranol leak?” Seeing that his remark received no reaction, he continued, “I wouldn’t say this is exactly the best place to go diving. The water is rather shallow,” looking over the parapet into the waves below. “Could break a few bones.”

“Tell me something I don’t know,” Iris replied gently, placing her elbows on the parapet, looking down at the waves.

“Aren’t you a joy to converse with,” Orion jokingly remarked, speaking directly at Iris. She carelessly observed the ripples in the water as they glared with reflections of the yellow patches on the LES. Sighing, he continued, “As... Her close friend, I am really doubtful that this would be what she’d want right now.”

Holding out the silence, she asserted, “Dead people don’t seem to want anything;” sharply turning to Orion to flatly ask, “do they?”

“Well, in that case, imagine for a second she is alive, would you say that—”

“I am *tired* of doing *that*,” Iris uttered with her breaking voice, trembling with frustration, stepping away from the parapet, with tears in her eyes. Orion stared at her, startled by the sudden escalation, though not surprised; trying to find the best approach for the situation at hand. He momentarily delved into the cyberspace with an expression of what Iris read as remorse. Running through the list of possible implications of that action, her heart skipped a beat. She decided that the best course of action would be to try to make amends and play the waiting game. She wiped her tears and apologized, “I’m sorry. I’ve been on edge recently I...”

“It’s okay, I get it. No need to apologize,” Orion picked up, looking out towards the city, admiring it, lightly swinging Iris’ bag in his hands, “tell you what, I need to get to Experté; why don’t you give me some company on the way, seeing as it is in the general direction of where you *should* be headed?”

Iris professed contrite agreement, and they both

started moving away from the scene. Orion passed the bag to Iris, and she slung it onto her left shoulder—always her left shoulder—automatically circling around Orion to be to his left. The gentle, cold, and salty-to-the-taste breeze loosened the tension in the air, allowing Iris to take deep breaths. In the ensuing silence, Orion prompted, “Would you care to explain what that was about?”

Iris took a while to respond, looking around while contemplating an answer. “Not something I could put into words—call it emotions running high, and,” she admitted, defeated, “Simply found myself in a place where things accumulated beyond a reasonable threshold; all I can say.”

As Orion was getting prepared to speak, Iris interjected, “Let us do without lectures, please? I know, I acted selfishly and made a mistake which could have proven costly, if not for myself, then others,” adding under her breath, “believe me, I know that.” *If others even care.* She continued, after a pause: “I appreciate your care and concern, but all I really need at the moment is familiar company. Could we switch to a different matter?” Receiving a “very well,” she inquired, “So, what is it you’re summoned to Experté for?”

Allowing for a change of character, Orion returned, “Not ‘summoned;’ I am here simply on a corporate diplomatic mission—an appointment with A-1’s council, to discuss Hover’s affairs.”

“Being part of Hover’s exec has altered more than your thinking patterns,” Iris remarked, turning to Orion. “It’s all about optics now;” she added, chuckling.

Without much protest, Orion admitted to being guilty—pointing out that the same was true for her.

She protested, “Please, that *stunt* has surely proved

optics are not at the forefront of my mind. Then again, I sincerely doubt my regular *surface-level* work will ever get to my head,” her voice noticeably trailing off.

Surface-level, huh? I am certain you would prefer its advantages, Orion voiced internally, an expression of doubt materializing on his face.

Stepping past the “welcoming” Ziro Haven autoscan turrets at the end of the bridge into Falçon park, Experté was but four city blocks away. Theoderau was truly tiny. It took about three and a half hours (at Iris’s moderate pace) to completely circle its perimeter—starting from Ridgeway on the respectively named island, North via Westcross onto Theoderau’s Radiance beach, then fully east by Sinclair through Falçon Park, fully south via Axisgate, and finally back west by Westcross onto Ridge island. Yet what it lacked in area it amply made up in volume. Even buildings at the edge of Falçon and Knox rivaled the height of the park’s white oaks, while middle-Knox left its pines in the dust, their crowns tens of degrees above horizon-level line of sight, with citytowers and Experté soaring higher yet, barely fitting into one’s field of vision top-to-bottom even this far out. Despite their height, Theoderauyan skyscrapers were unbothered by violent upper-altitude wind—the LES being to blame. For a time in its history, the city had no wind, until vegetation and estates began showing signs of decaying structural integrity, at which point artificial biosphere management systems had been implemented, with wind, rain, and sunshine managed by the circular structure on which the LES was sitting.

Theoderau’s active nightlife had faded around two hours ago, and daytime would only start in one—Falçon park therefore devoid of intransient visitors, though in letting through next to all in- and out-bound traffic for 1-North it was far from empty. Murmuring banter, so

distinct from the anxiety of 1-North, and the occasional humming streetcar, filled the midnight park. Hefty, rocky, lush hills, with ferns and shrubs and dwarf trees, artistically arranged to be pleasing to the eye, kept in pristine condition; winding wooden trails diverging into the park from dual-lane now brick Altaire blvd., with naturalisesque stone benches and two streetcar stops placed adjacently; cobblestone bridges over streams and a pond of crystal-clear water; lamp-posts providing just enough illumination—everything was made to be as soothing as possible. Iris smiled. Though, the storm on the outside, unlike life on the inside, was visibly intensifying, with small white cracks appearing in the center of the yellow islands cruising through the LES.

The rustle of wet leaves filled the cold night air. On the topic of nature and parks, Iris continued, “Just step outside the LES and it is like this for tens of thousands of kilometres: magna natura. Aside from the corroded vetus mundus and its undiluted vieuxtritol.” Vieuxtritol was the marketing name of Thezeraine’s early-days’ nouveau energy source “nitritol.” Organically stable, easily absorbable, biomechanically disruptive, incredibly toxic, and deadly. Though not entirely dissimilar to modern day nitritol, vieuxtritol gathered such a horrendous reputation of ripping one’s skin with mottling scars upon contact it had to be distanced from. What was worse, A-1’s biosphere evolved primitive plant forms, “sparkles,” that, on critical mass, produced and stored vieuxtritol as an energy source, destining A-1 to irrecoverably be filled with poison.

“What a suicide mission that would be, even with proper gear,” Orion pointed out, *and for what?* looking back for a glimpse of the LES, noticing the signatures of “white death” in the shield—discolorment that comes

with high nitritol discharge, the en'rainfall from the storm boiling off.

The sky above was covered by rainless ironwood clouds; the lightly tilted lithosol slope on which Orion and his group were now, intermittent with black bedrock, with scattered patches of dirt, mixed with sand, and gravel; patches of grass dispersed all around, at times featuring a lonely pine. The steppe was hardly a dozen kilometers off the shore of the Atlantic, in a shadow zone following eastside sierras, with Theoderau not more than a hundred clicks away. Orion sat chipping away at a display, trying different configurations for a trailing Aegis shield, spun by an extendable arm with an adjustable RPM. He put down the tablet, and leant in his helmet against his thick shielded gloves in disgruntlement. The wind was picking up, making the grass rustle. Raising his head, he became captivated by the patterns air produced as it ran through the grass. So many years on, and we still try to catch up to nature. Orion looked back at the team, with such strong collaborative effort assembling the Hover. *Carpe diem*—he chuckled, *today's the day*. With luck on our side, anyway. He turned back to fiddling with power curves. Seeing some progress, he sat back with a smile.

He jolted back by his tablet beginning to fizzle, a black area on the screen making it scream. He ripped out the plug for the arm, coming in on the radio, "En'rain! En'rain!"

"Affirm; retire to safety," he received from Seth, the operation lead. Powering on the Aegis shields above the exo-suite, he briskly walked to the team, almost slipping on the gravel. He assisted in the retrieval of critical components, lending number 17 a hand in getting down from the wing with the Central Control Block, himself moving around to rip out prototype trailing Aegis

blocks, keeping them safe from the rain as he and so many others moved to camp.

Sitting by the operation control panel in the garage, Orion ranted to Seth, “En’rain—in a shadow zone! So much carcass going to waste...”

Even inside the suites, one could hear the screeching boil of vieuxtritol against the fully-powered nitritol aegis shields. Seth laclusterly replied, verifying functionality of the retrieved devices, “The priciest parts have been salvaged; rebuilding the rest will take only a bit of time.” Orion sighed, hearing Seth continue, “Just be thankful it’s just en’rain, Endell. Could be much, much worse.”

Iris turned to Orion, her eyes shining with the desire to make the perfect witty remark, but she deemed it inappropriate and stopped herself. Orion continued, “That which is most captivating is often the source of the greatest peril. Coined that piece of wisdom in an engineering test.”

Iris guessed, “I would suppose that to be the purpose of your ‘corporate diplomatic mission’?”

Orion smiled. Iris continued her inquiry, pitching in a salesmanish manner to the trees to the sides of Altaire, arms spread wide as if the sidewalk of the boulevard was a runway podium, turning to various sides—her bag turning about with her, catching stray glances, “Vacuum Tunneling—all over every Thezerainian media outlet! The long awaited solution to maglev maintenance made possible by Hover’s and Aegis’s tireless collaboration!”

“Whoa there, tune down the enthusiasm. Maglevs aren’t going anywhere,” Orion joyfully assured her.

Iris momentarily turned her eyes to Orion in slight disbelief, then gaily continued, “Picture the convenience of a hover passing through the LES and docking safely in the Ridgemere harbor—no more hour long train

rides, no more navigating Theoderau's befuddling city grid, no more——!"

As Iris was looking around, searching for inspiration for a third point to her argument, Orion interjected, laughing in disbelief, "You are unbelievable—an AV won't suffice?" adding, "and hadn't you slept on the transit back?"

"Details," Iris quickly returned, "—but how do you know?"

"I assumed; you did blow past me on the VacTrain," Orion said, watching Iris connect the dots, snapping back to the topic: "Though, the act of 'Hover will be utilizing Aegis shields to dynamically construct a portable vacuum tunnel' does not necessarily entail that 'Hover will be introducing technological interdependence into critical apparatus,'" Orion said, turning to Iris, "with the current situation at hand, the last thing anyone could possibly want is a 'Light Thezeraine'-esque fait accompli—or that of Nolan Forgrave, at that."

Leaving the park, the breeze behind them was fading—the city ethereal, shining like a violent starwind aurora, splurging its iridescent palette onto everything. It was quietened in the face of the night, though not devoid of its enchanted nocturnal admirers—as Iris put it, ever an idealistic romantic—murmuring in the night streets – their sights kept off the ground by radiant skystrips and jumbotrons, keeping the city flashing as ever: the city made so much more embellishing by the glittering wet surface reflections of their illumination. On the street-level, to either side of them were dark fashion storefronts with glowing fascia and blade signs, deserted in the night cafés, their decorative flowery vegetation being sprinkled by the night rain, lone plastic benches for the weary commuter that were made ever so slightly inoperative by the rain, courtyard

chairs folded and put away with stacked tables – Iris had entertained the thought of whether the tables, too, were “contaminated” with discourse regarding Raydeucar. Above the immediate street, amidst the lightstrips and jumbotrons were offices, studios, and apartments: some still having their lights on, the city never fully asleep. Iris, making an instantaneous associative connection, was struck mentally off-balance—internally attempting to switch gears in a way to throw off her thought process. Failing to do so, she fell back into conversation by allowing Orion to spin the preaching that was perceptibly on the top of his mind, opening for dialogue with the first example he mentioned, “How is interdependence connected to having your rifle forcecooked?”

That Light Thezeraine, the daughter of the last pre-collapse emperor, is the person whose untimely death is said to have triggered the empire’s downfall is common knowledge. Her death occurred in a crackdown raid on under-the-counter vieuxtritol production deep in the Lumen district, Theoderau, which was the then-capital of Thezeraine—during which her rifle is said to have been remotely overcooked as a result of its opulent Anti[E]therium Generators (AEGs) being inundated and exploded with the purple terror. Specifically in Theoderau, her legacy is a weathered bronze statue at the corner of Crescendo and Blackstone, in Portland—and a widely-preached tale of corporate security caution.

As anticipated, the subject clearly having been grounds for thought, Orion began, “After doing some research, it was established that the sole culprit of the accident was a three-way, although sophisticated and secure, AL-2 link between Hover, Caoz, and Aegis devices. A QE vulnerability—“Hertzbleed”—allowed for a vectored attack, issued from none other than her own compromised hover—you know the rest.” Iris

moodily nodded. Unconsciously skimming through the dark interiors of establishments while brooding over the matter, he shook his head, adding, “No, every single n’n’a-powered [nitritol n’ antitherium] device must function standalone. Considerable as the benefits would be, the risks are never going to be worth it.” After a pause, he continued, “What makes ops such as G7-V masterclasses is the presence of multilevel fallbacks for every stage.”

Really was born a millennium and a bit too late, Iris voiced to herself, perseverating, content with the change in her mood, allowing Orion thoughtspace. *Things have never been the same without you two, you know that?* she internally asked, neither expecting a response nor ever receiving one. With her indifference falling apart the more she gave it thought, Iris relegated her focus back upon the city. Theoderau—she took the city, with all its sparkling magnificence, in with a breath of warming air—the magnificent city of thought. Theoderau’s inner-ring—coupled with Ridgeway Island—formed a rather unique architectural gradient between outer-ring apartmental buildings and the City Center’s stratoscraper. Altaire, in living up with its name, had by this point spread out into a fully fledged boulevard, with streetcar rails put over a grassbed between its brick lanes, sighting one running every so often due to three overlapping routes. It was touched up with flowery shrubs, purple butterfly, pink azalea, and red camelia among others, and dwarf pines, too—though, this was very Theoderau-anesque, and tonight there was no reason to adore the ordinary. Drifting along their side of the lane, her eyes snapped on a Maison Floiré cafe, a chain for which she harbored a particular fondness, with some ill-will. It was not that long ago that she would at times stop by and grab a salmon croissant—the best

item on the menu to this day, according to her—after the day at the academy, in-lieu of dinner. A long, drudgerous couple of hours of ingesting information behind, with more hours to let her creativity ablaze by the warmly-sterile hue of her desk lamp queued in – with a croissant or another baked good to break up her day. Whether she missed those days or not she could not tell—and if she did, it was not because of “things being simpler” or “times being better,” for she was young enough to remember those things to not be true. What she had lost was the innocence of ignorance, of unawareness, of having no other choice—for the choice of the salmon croissant was no choice at all, as a selection must have been made at the end of the day, even that of no dinner at all—but in return she gained a certain Invictus-esque self-cognizance, of the usefulness of which she was either unaware or uncertain, and perhaps ignorant. In any case, she resurfaced: had it not been late in the night, she would have perhaps gone in and grabbed that croissant—after a bit of further thought, she decided to rainticket that idea. For after all, between Evenfall and its ops and the latest drudgery, spending a night in the fresh air was, to her, the best place she could hope to be.

“Iris?” Orion asked for her.

“Yeah?” she jolted her head in response, adjusting back to reality.

“Awfully silent again. Just checking.”

“No reason for concern,” she explained, “I was just reminiscing over my days at TCA.”

“Harboring fond memories of Theoderau Central?” Orion inquired in a pleased manner, turning to Iris.

“Some,” she shrugged in return, adding with a disappointed sigh, “most of them involving Sonnet.”

Following the sudden drop of poise, he remarked, “I

am sorry to have heard about her.”

Iris tilted her head skyward, letting the rain fall on her face, her sight ripping past the titanium-framed skyscrapers, focusing on the storm beyond the chromatically-flowing blue, green, yellow, white LES. Lowering her head and breaking the silence, she said, tearing up, “Matter of life, I suppose.” Orion sighed, unnerved with compassion, looking downward. After a while, Iris hesitantly resumed, with palpable difficulty, “I remember this...” Orion looked towards Iris, partaking in her sorrow. “It was my sophomore year of senior period, and I violently choked the half-semester of multivariable differential analysis. Happens, right?” she asked, looking towards Orion for affirmation – he returned a slight gesture of agreement, “Anyway, I came straight home, breaking my familiar routine, and completely broke down, not without reason, but I just... fully lost it.” Taking a deep breath she continued, with a slight uplift in her tone, “Yet not an hour later, Sonnet and I were on 15th, a bench looking out towards the infinite coastal line bordering the Atlantic trailing off into the horizon, my beloved salmon croissant lying on my lap,” sighing, she concluded, “Comforted.”

In response to the ensuing silence, Iris continued, hopefulness in her voice, “There were darker times, of course, but... We all persevered.”

“Perhaps this time it will not be all too different?” Orion suggested.

Iris sighed, “Yeah, well...” trailing off, becoming stale.

She became overrun by the sensation of a gaping wound in her chest, carved in by anxiety. Unable to chalk it up, she let it eat at her, meantime trying to keep an eye on her surroundings; looking for control; shifting her focus from glittering lamppost, to soaked-

through bench, to the adjacent lush privet. She was noticing objects but was finding it increasingly difficult to see them. Managing her breathing similarly amounted to nothing. She was accustomed to routinely ruminating over present matters while being fully engulfed in her memoir—recently, mulling over news of Raydeucar, revelation of Vacuum Tunneling, her last failed clandestine op, the... Iris sultrily observed how the outlines of objects began to merge and blur, smearing; her vigilance becoming substituted by haze, dissociating, alprazolam kicking into gear; how she was moving forward, but every step felt like a retreat, a turn, sinking her deeper and further into the insurmountable maze that everything was. All while pondering three questions: *Was that life really better? Was it more preferable? What about now?*

Orion noticed her once again turning silent, but allowed her to take her course, trusting she would find a way out. All the while, he had been rehearsing key points for the upcoming meeting and simulating probable stations the meeting could sojourn. “*Vacuum Tunneling may prove of critical importance at providing the upper hand shall the not unlikely doomsday prognosis take place,*” he internally repeated, “*not being able to secure an immediate choke-hold on the situation in the event of an escalation will come costly.*” He threw a glance around Altaire, always boiling with life but now so unusually still. Curse it all..., he thought, *I’m an engineer, not a harbinger. All of this is just playing on fears: VT guzzles up so much power it depletes nitritol as if it were an actual supercapacitor. The prospect of using antitherium in a highly mobile craft should by itself alienate anyone in their right mind, less they make-wish a portable supernova. The technology is just plain not ready for deployment.* Orion sighed, raising his head to sideline a glance towards

Atlas Rise, a soaring skyscraper to his right and the last vestige of Knox before Centrale. He gave it a welcoming smile expressing a fondness of the place.

The effervescent and bright conjoint play of the orchestra spun the expanded atrium, intensifying the vivid colors under the flowing lights, sparkling so deep in the Friday evening. The dripping light strips, harmoniously pulsating with the sound, illuminated the array of two-seat metallic glass dining tables, covered by vinyl tablecloths with cutlery and low cuboid vases filled with seasonal pansies on top, positioned to face the elevated stage—the wall behind it made up of tinted displays, adjusting the visuals to accompany the symphony as it progressed. Opposite the stage was a bar, lit up in green and teal lights, with seated upon bar stools members enjoying the show, layers and layers of rooms and zones echoing above them. Reclining on a table positioned to his side, Orion observed the synchronous movement of the ensemble, brooding over Hover's latest affairs, axially rotating a glass of rum in his left hand. He looked to his right, where Atlas Rise opened through a large panel of glass towards continental Aethelon. Taking a glance at the orchestra, Orion lightly, yet firmly, put down his glass, waiting for an interlude to occur. Once the atrium erupted with applause, he discreetly made his way through the crowd towards the balcony, passing the glass doors, and breathing in the cold air—the balcony fervent with feisty cocktail discussion, clusters of people discussing latest policy matters over filled with sparkling champagne flutes, enjoying the heightened view over the streets below. Orion made his way closer to the guardrail, placing his hands securely on it, admiring the golden-sunset view from the top of the world, regretting he couldn't enjoy it. *Curse it all...*, he flung to the world, his face acquiring

a degree of distraughtness. Scanning his surroundings, he went over the barely visible in the dusk Aethelon, lit Theoderauyan streets, the streetcars moving along Altaire below, an AV rushing by via its air-canal towards Portland, the city grid opening to the central lineup, with Trinity row running alongside them, and the life inside, beside, and above him. Orion sighed in frustration, gently hitting the guardrail. Closing his eyes, he took a deep breath of fresh air in. Tilting his head to view the balcony, as he was about to turn back to his melancholy, he recognized a familiar face, who in turn noticed him. After the palpably prudent figure excused themselves from the group with a polite smile and a gesture, they headed towards Orion.

“Orion,” the councillor called up with shining cordiality, positioning themselves to his side, grabbing onto the guardrail.

“Marcus.” Orion acknowledged.

“Quite the while since I last sighted you at Atlas, wouldn’t you agree?” he politely inquired in return.

“You could say that again,” Orion prolonged with an unexcused sigh, “At some point, work just consumes you whole, especially if you let it,” he laughed off.

Marcus replied, “Would that be the reason why you find fresh air more enticing than the Friday evening symphony?” Turning to Orion, he smiled, voicing with reassurance, “It is quite the lovely evening.”

Orion took a deep breath and turned towards the city center, eyeing Shardline for a couple seconds before letting the air out in a deep sigh.

Continuing the conversation, Marcus remarked, “I have heard that Hover’s Engineering Board is doing particularly well.”

“As always.”

Marcus smiled. He continued, “Well, I personally do find this aerosplit prototype rather enticing. It is, but, a matter of getting the right people interested.”

“Not exactly our prevailing priority,” Orion once again prolonged.

“And being a downer of course contributes to the aim,” Marcus returned.

“It’s——” Orion tried, but stalled in not knowing how to proceed.

Breaking the silence, Marcus asserted, “When you are a leader, those around you watch your every step, every shift in sentiment. Learn to manage your own psychology or succumb to the most common pitfall: *resentment*.”

Orion looked straight ahead, slightly nodding to himself. He checked on Iris, quite silent, whose eyes had not considered him in a while, arms crossed, only being on the look-out for the occasional curb; her Aegis shields were disabled, everything otherwise seemed in order. Orion smiled. *But what risks wouldn't we take for the safety of those we love... At the end of the day, I just hope Auralie gets to see a fraction of the benefit everyone reaps from her ploys at Raydeucar.*

Disenchanted nighttime Theoderauyan streets, Iris began, “Though, I suppose it would only take one hover to turn Theoderau into a large-scale domino tray.”

“Pardon?” Orion asked, presenting an addled façade to Iris, though quite happy to see her persevering on her own. *Hasn't lost it all, contrary to what everyone believes.*

“VT interconnectivity—I mean,” she clarified, “Don’t believe the board would exactly turn ecstatic upon contemplating that possibility in the framework of my proposal,” smiling to herself, quietly adding, “though I do suppose they would’ve thought of that within the

first few moments?...”

Orion smiled.

Revitalized, taking a few brisk steps, and beginning to walk backwards, confident in not falling over, Iris continued, “Speaking of the council: as VT is a collaborative effort between Hover and Aegis, I would assume another party to be present during the discussion...?” she hung in the air, tilting her head in the inquiry.

Orion admitted, “You would be correct.” With a note of pride, he added, “Amelie Flanigan will also be present at the meeting.”

Hearing that name, Iris almost paid the price for her cockiness to the bricklane, taken aback and stared at Orion, bewildered, ever so slightly shellshocked.

“En route—and yes, VT’s of that significance. Darius would also be here, were the situation not what it is.” Orion sighed, “Urgent affairs at every HQ, Aegis’s included. You know why firsthand. Learning of the delay, thought of staying back for a couple of moments at Atlas, nostalgia being the driving factor.”

Still in shock, Iris halted, with Orion following suit. She looked onto Atlas Rise, catching a glimpse of it before turning to Orion and politely inquiring whether he would prefer to go through with the original plan.

“A compelling option, yet I am still intent on arriving at Experté—let the past beget the past;” Orion replied, “Furthermore, I find it difficult to trust a certain someone enough to let her wander off on her own.” Iris looked down, asking, “Please?”

Orion looked away, likely considering the best response to the situation at hand. Iris added, “I will let you know when I get to the apartment,” becoming mortified at her digging her own grave. After a while,

Orion turned back, beginning, “Alright, there are two things I will say: I hope you have taken to heart how stupid what you tried doing today is.” Iris lowered her eyes further yet. “Second,” Orion paused for a second, attempting a change of tone, “I can’t imagine how difficult things have been as of late, but that is no reason to let up. Lighter days are still to come, just give them a chance.” She silently nodded. Orion finished with, “Alright, then. Hop onto 7th—I believe it moves to Ridgeway?—and do ping me back when you land in one piece. Take care.”

“Have fun,” Iris replied.

One-on-one with Theoderauyan streets again, her wariness starting to take over, she limped over to the nearest stop, feeling the falldown of the day. Disenchanted with the city in this sorrowing night, all she began to long for was to get to the refuge of her apartment, the stillness of it becoming ever so enticing. As she was checking for trams before crossing the boulevard, she gave a glance to Shardline—a two tower building, which unlike the now adjacent cascading blades of Experté, was blocklike, stacking down—admittedly finding it ironic that, for all the time spent in qualifying on the 61st floor, of how little assistance it proved at the most critical moment. Distraught, she pulled up the schedule of the 7th route via her neural interface, realizing she would have to hurry up to catch it in a minute’s time. Shifting from Knox to Centrale, it became prominently convenience-oriented, with courts shifting further inwards and supportive outdoor public infrastructure – in turn of which slick items were favored: soaring strip displays, living plant walls, piled signage – experiencing a noticeable cut as to not obfuscate the grandeur of the architectural pinnacle that were the aspiring stratoscrapers and allow for

greater transportation throughput. “*Enchanting enough to be satisfactory*,” would be how Iris often put it during her ventures in the “city of thought;” perhaps somewhat biased by TCA, two blocks southeast from where she was positioned now, whose indoor spaces were entirely enviable. Between it and Shardline, she found the former infinitely more preferable for its interpersonal-interaction-oriented approach, zones changing thematically top to bottom, each area having a unique layout, fostering independent study by inspiring curiosity as the core of its interior design—as opposed to Shardline; at the end of the day, she would classify Evenfall as the merging of the two.

Getting to the metal-carcassed stop on time, which shielded those under it from the rain with glass ceilings also a home to a moss wall on the rear; she entered the white-blue streetcar on the far end, and put herself to recline against the back of the cabin, preferring it to the cushty sitting. The 7th line running from west to southeast, it was not subject to the transportation crisis of the two lines delivering traffic to the station, which perfectly explained the two cabins being relatively empty. As the streetcar began to accelerate, she let her head rest on the back glass display. Looking to her right, she gave a shifting sight to Shardline as the streetcar was drifting onwards to Bloomfield avenue; as it were, it seemed to her that everything was intent on reminding her. *Of all things that could have happened during “Pisces...”* Iris thought, defenseless.

Sitting behind her desk in the third live operation room in the B2 layer of Evenfall—a large box, with three step-up layers, filled with operators; the wall before her a geometric labyrinth pattern on top of triangular sound-isolation foam; to her left, an underpass at the back of the first level, delving under the second layer

to lead to a corridor—she was directing Sonnet with rigidity, “Signature on W.X., level. Maintain course, possible lefthand hazard.”

“Is epsilon holding up?” Sonnet inquired over the radio.

“Excellently,” Iris replied, with an audible smile.

Her anxiety pumping up in fear of hell breaking loose, she was ravenously reading into the metrics and telemetry provided by the live feeds, put up on large panels in front of her, giving insight into apparati temperature, wear, damage, dissymmetry, dynamic environment scans, reads of ongoing operational signatures, status, statistics, perspectives—acting as an assistive copilot, providing quintessential intel alone—she maintained her poise under pressure, reporting back to her, continuing communication, “status green, apparati in order, path unobstructed, keep con-ops.”

Overhearing instances of excessive calling, she received “Shots fired behind,” from Amber. “Investigating,” she replied immediately, beginning to rapidly read through logs and others’ feeds, and after to her great confusion gaining the revelation of a penetration by Raydeucar’s Elite Force—getting fortuitously entangled in the op, acting against it, unaware—proclaimed, leaning in: “E.F. caused distress calls behind. Crossfire. Extraction alpha advised. Hovers are on standby,” receiving strong-worded frustration in return, “Not a fucking option, Iris. We’ll push.”

“Copy. Restructuring,” Iris replied, switching comms to Taylor, one-up visor, and pitching him: “We have 1-81, 1-81. Extraction declined by team. Actionplan?” — “We’re on it! Push!” Iris returned to Sonnet, pronouncing: “Idris will switch to follow. Uhh,” she panicked, making a call, “S.Q.D. is 30 off set to defense. Trying to reach E.F. to clear up. Push greenlit.” — “Copy.”

Though trying to not let it show in her voice, Iris sat petrified, realizing the threat that the pivot presented—taught how to deal with distress, but not when there were personal matters at stake. Iris, momentarily glowering, thought over the warning she received from Preston Scofield, head of division, regarding the dangers of professional entanglement, this cannot be happening, no, not again, not again! Raising her head, she fearfully pitched in, “Incoming, dual sequence, breaker swifts, Equinox, support system warmed up, initialize Aegis.” Watching the readings tick up, measuring seconds by every third heartbeat, towards contact with breaker-type vector Caoz rifles with terror, *just our damn luck to have triple-T piercers against breakers, even if they're tetranol; come on, Amber, Sonnet, I know your reaction times are superior*; she gravely asserted, “Inbound,” watching the encounter unravel.

As Iris said that, the radio clicked – comms went down with Amber, then Sonnet.

Iris stood in the streetcar, holding onto a rail by her hip as it was turning right on Westcross, she observed the discolored cabin, dispirited. Though her perception was not completely off, the cabin was far from sterile. In spite of not being empty—hosting approximately a dozen people—it was quite dormant, with every passenger appearing to have worked a day-long shift. There was, nonetheless, a sense of buoyancy, so lacking in other parts of the city. *Why me?* she spun at herself again, *I wish I lost the ability to...*, lowering her ambitions with a scoff, sentencing: *no*. The interior of the streetcar strongly resembled that of the VacTrain, with the exception of it focusing on short-term travel—numerous cerulean poles stemming from in-between of the numerous light blue-cushioned gray transverse seatings, towards the singular row of yellow overhead-lighting panes. To all

sides, there were transparent infotainment displays—featuring headlines, No mention of Raydeucar, scrolling downwards; alongside a shrunk right-side column, hosting current time, next stop, the path of the line with the current position, and the running schedule—with an approximately 1.8m main diagonal. Every four metres, the cabins were segmented by black rubber spacers, allowing the tram to turn—it being on rails, often over a grass path, allowed it to both run with superior efficiency, silence, and throughput: the main reason Theoderau did not allow the possession of any other forms of transportation without a special permit—emergency services and VIP transportation being allowed to use tram-tracks and strictly-defined air-corridors—besides bicycles.

Iris lightly hit her head against the back pane. With sharp mental pain, she returned, *that soul-crushing silence after the click—no matter how much you call, there is simply no reply.* To her left, was the opening towards the infinite cobalt Atlantic running along the coast of Aethelon. Lifelessly remembering all the great moments she had on this view, she tore at herself, *and how much more painful that becomes, when a beloved part of you is ripped out—by your own doing, too. The only thing I am glad about is being left uncaught in the ensuing scandal centering around making Raydeucar so “antsy.”*

Having informally reported to central control regarding the incident, she observed the operation crumble, stuck in a state of disassociation, not able to feel or think in the state of shock. The flashing green dots trickle down to red before turning off completely, more and more so, carving out a disproportionate portion, but, nonetheless, being swamped. In retrospect, the unanimous decision to charge ahead rivaled the absurdity and amplitude of powergate. Having been

briefed on the fact that the op was infiltrated, she submitted the “accident” report, and sat through the fallout of piscesfall blowing past her, being elevated higher and higher in the execution chain, over to the in the night Imperial Council, the toll of heads rolling increasing long after the drapes had been hung on the grounds of the bloodbath.

A couple of hours down the line, very early in the morning, extremely sleep deprived, she was sitting across Yasmin—her friend with whom she bonded over the nightmares of TCA—who arrived early to provide mental support, similarly shellshocked by pisces, in the cafeteria of Evenfall.

“God...” Yasmin said.

Iris sighed. “Yeah...”

“Were you close to your third operatee?” a woman asked her, wrapping up the questioning.

Looking down at the steel table stained with her blood, she replied, “Yes.”

“We appreciate your definite recollection of events, and we are very sorry for your loss, Ms. Feverenn,” the woman gravely asserted, “However, as you yourself understand, you are in no condition to remain in Evenfall Q3. You are discharged until further notice.”

“Undestood.”

Standing alone in the hallway next to a potted plant, she scoffed. “Fucking Amber.” Having, by this point, substituted grief with rage, she screamed: “When we meet, I will fucking rip you apart!”

The cafeteria where she was now sitting was a truly lovely place, though none of its comforts cured the morning of the eeriness in the face of the events that unfolded tonight. Iris had ordered nothing but dark coffee, which had turned cold. Yasmin inquired to her,

“What happened to your hand?”

Moments before piscifall had begun, she temporarily left her desk, and walked outside the live-ops room into the dimly-lit and silent in the face of the night corridors to the nearest restroom. Putting her hands onto the blackstone countertop, staring into the mirror. She noticed her own paleness, examining it further from different angles, looking onto the black backwall. After washing her hands, she listened in, hearing nothing but mortal silence. She wiped her hands dry, and tore into her left hand to mute her scream, digging into the flesh with her prominent fangs until she felt the bittersweet taste of metal, releasing it and beginning to cry, putting her ripped up hand over the sink, blood dripping; breaking down over the stained sink.

“Exactly what happened to all of us,” she replied to Yasmin with a shallow smile, picking up the teaspoon to stir her coffee.

The streetcar making its penultimate stop before she'd have to step off, Iris looked at her masked scars, *at least you never had to live with the excruciating pain of being the central cause of so much harm, walking out of the massacre completely dry, unstained. Perhaps the best thing I could do is join you... two.*

Hearing the pling, she walked out of the streetcar to the stop in the middle of Ridgeway Island, on Sixth. She turned to head to her apartment building, now but a couple of deep breaths away. Ridgeway, in many ways, resembled Lower Western with its countless apartment buildings, though scaled inwards and expanded upwards, up to eighteen floors at the highest, made panelled, with variable extrusion and vertical and horizontal planks of contrasting colors to emphasize the character of the buildings; the full-height windows made of polarized

glass, allowing for variable transparency, though the lobbies often were semi-transparent. The rain had ceased, though the street was still wet, and the walls occasionally sent droplets to splatter on the ground. The storm outside had calmed, the sky was getting lighter in the face of dawn, turning to an aegean hue in the east. Somewhat revitalized, Iris walked through the familiar streets, paying little attention to the corner shops, the excessive courtyards, the trails leading down to the promenade, and the one of the six playgrounds in the entirety of Theoderau. Having made her way across to the corner of seventh, she stepped up the slate stairs of her apartment building, opening the reinforced glass doors with a biometric scan. Walking through the doors, the lobby blasted out a gust of warm, dry air, reminding her of the late ventures she would make into the city not that long ago, before everything had fallen apart. She gave a glance to the modern organic lobby, with a marble floor and pillars running up to the white concrete ceiling; the left hand side featured living spaces, with growing birch trees spacing the walls; opposite that was the check-in terminal and the reception's & bar services' volumetric-geometry wooden desk; finally, before her was the decorative wooden maze leading to the two building elevators and public services—the space oftentimes used for public social events. She walked to the check-in system, authenticated, and placed an order for groceries, scheduling it to come in to the 85th in ten hours, hoping to have had enough sleep by then. She turned back and made her way past the overrun-by-magazines glass coffee table featuring a sapling of a cherry tree surrounded by the slightly worn felt chairs and the reception desk's banker lamps to the elevator corridor.

She was pleasantly surprised to find an elevator on

the floor level, guessing it to have been an early-bird on their way outside. As she pressed the button to open the elevator door, she noticed the cranberry juice spilled on the floor—or at least it smelled like that. Carefully getting inside the Auerolin elevator, she leaned onto the control panel for support, examining the cranberry juice on the floor, pushing the button to rise to the 8th floor, quickly following it with the “close the doors” button. As the elevator began moving upwards, Iris let out a relieved sigh. Looking up to the white dots that were the elevator lights, she became mesmerized, contemplating the effect the elevator becoming stuck, as it once did on her, would have. Looking below, she felt like she picked up a rusty scent, though did not give it much further thought.

Disenchanted from her reverie by the elevator’s doors opening as it arrived on 8th, she made her way on the lined carpet, to her apartment, 85, and unlocked it with a card. Walking in, she undressed without much care, putting matters of tidiness off until later today, like many other things. She dropped off her Aegis shields and apartment card on the counter, turned dusty of it not having been cleaned in the last three weeks; all its 51 sqm being uncared for, though not made a mess off. She was on her way to drop off her structured bag in her room, the smaller of the two—though there has been no reason to stay in the smaller one for the past two months—yet halted in the hallway, putting her structured bag down. She reached for a photoframe on the wall, cleaning it off with her healing wrist, looking at it with a warm and tender sight. The group photo featured herself at a very young age, the photo being taken around eighteen years ago. She continuously looked at the photo, becoming more and more immersed in thought, focusing on one particular aspect of it.

Letting out a sigh, she recited, “So should I, after the tea and cakes and—”

“Iris!” she heard, recognizing a familiar voice, instantly turning to the living room with frightened eyes; jumping back in fear, she dropped the frame. Upon impact, it split into two parts, large shards of glass breaking off, disassembling the white light of the apartment into a rainbow, as they pirouetted through the air, at their roughened edges.

\$ Breakthrough

“Allow me to present to you,” Wilhelm displayed to Alfred, “the prototype of a man-portable and manufacturable ‘trial triple tolerance’ powered railgun.”

They stood in a shooting range next to the rifle fixated to a worn stand, no more than seventy centimeters lengthwise in appearance, remarkably low-profile. The design was distinctively that of an engineering proof-of-concept: not field ready, though it was boastfully showing off its compressed geometry.

“Has it been tested?” Alfred inquired.

Zealous, Wilhelm continued, “Yes! With promising results,” he picked up a tablet with metrics, showing visualizations and graphs, “the device was able to sustain accelerating bullets up to two and a half kilometers a second—beyond that, it snaps. However, it could hypothetically deliver a payload at more than ten kilometers a second, albeit as a suicide weapon.”

Alfred gave it a detailed inspection, weighing what had been said. “It is admirably terrifying,” he concluded.

“Would you like to see its capabilities live?” Wilhelm returned.

Alfred smiled, “That is why I am here.”

Standing behind the multilayer EM-shield-complemented protective window, the rifle was primed to fire at a steel wall with a depth approximating current-gen MBTs’ shielding. Assuring safety on the polygon, the railgun was primed; as it was condensing air with

its cryogenic cooling, it was set to fire once at a clamped speed. After the ensuing hypersonic thunderclap, the implosion of which was reverberating in chests through walls, the bullet blazed the air—a portable lightning—leaving a trail of blue plasma and a shimmering-like pathway in the air, with the steel plate compromised: vaporized at the point of impact, shattered elsewhere; the railgun in-tact, remaining in the same spot, blowing off white smoke to cool itself down.

Stunned by the ghastly scene, Alfred mouthed:

“Raging fire,
Dear infernal gyre.”

Weeks prior, presenting his work to Monte, his close friend and a triple-T research associate, Wilhelm received, “How can you be proud of this?! This is absolutely against everything we stand for; all of our attempts to get along will be shattered!” he stepped up closer, “I beg of you, do not release this—” he pointed to the disassembled railgun, “this—and I am sorry to call it that—mistake which is worse than the advent of antitherium!”

“Two sides to every coin, Monte,” Wilhelm defensively returned.

Monte continued the offense, “Then think of which side will be used! Think of Oppenheimer, do you want to be engulfed in remorse as he once was? This is not just immoral, it is——!” He gave up, groaning in intense frustration.

Wilhelm asserted, walking closer to the disassembled barrel, “Ethics always fall to the backstage when you are chasing for a breakthrough.”

II. In The Air Tonight



C-783RF “Fracture”

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“This is a suicide mission,” Reese exclaimed to the woman across the table.

“I assure you that it is not,” the woman replied. “We will go into further details once we have your agreement.”

“Out of the question,” Reese continued, with no further consideration: “no.”

He sat on a couch in the foyer of Equinox’s HQ, Reveillane; sighing, he went out for a walk. Emerging on Raydeucar’s East-7 Madgement road, facing the opposing park, he turned left, heading down the street. He sighed, *on this trajectory, the only thing Equinox will achieve is splitting up Thezeraine. Breaking loose of IC is a wish for many, but with this...* he gave up.

Brooding further on routine matters, he passed through blocks: leafy vines hung over fronts and over streets, flowers put into barrels – both unloaded from MUVs, pole-mounted decor: all in preparation for the upcoming Longest Day celebration. Cars were silently cruising by, the streets bustling with life, rich with sounds and music, the gentle wind refreshing in the daytime heat. Lt. Canmore was a tall man—currently enlisted in the IF—ripped from strenuous training, equipped with an amped Apex military implant set,

with a remarkably unremarkable face. Spending his entire life in Raydeucar, he received the invitation to join the Imperial Force's regional subdivision: the Raydeucar Elite Force – REF. Reluctantly, he deemed it best; siding with the Equinox collective, then, for him was a personal matter.

Examining a mounted on the wall nitritol C-434GM:B “Mercy” back in Reveillane, Reese recalled his first encounter with “breaker”-type ammunition on a polygon. He recalled watching his instructor prime the worn, *far inferior* to the “Mercy” nitritol C-361GP:B “Power,” fascinated by the display of it priming its cooling systems; with the splitting distance of the breakers manually tuned, she put it into firing mode, then aimed it at a silicone doll on the opposite end of the underground range. No person in the room observed the “Power” in action, focusing on the doll: right before impact, the breaker split, its beak opening, expanding its four arms, producing a loud supersonic whiplash; the doll was cut into four slices – the jelly-like substance inside erupted backwards, the pieces pulled together before being thrown apart. At the time, he felt nothing, neither terror nor excitement. Nothing.

“Rifles and similar Powerline-enabled accessories are divided into three grades:” his instructor once opened, “tetranitrel-, nitritol-, and antitherium-powered.

“To this day, naming conventions between suppliers remain disparate. The ‘Portable Caoz Standard’ was created to counter that—the central board mandates that any IF trainee refers to rifles according to this standard. Any entry under the standard opens with a ‘C-’, followed by the LRPN number, or Logarithmic Relative Power Number.” She paused. “An LRPN in the 100-200 range is typically tetranitrel, 300-600 customarily is

nitritol, and 700+ is antitherium augmented. Following this convention, 'C-360' indicates that the rifle is nitritol and a 'C-800' indicates that the rifle is certainly using antitherium. Questions?"

Later at night, in a discussion about highest-ranked rifles under the Caoz standard, Reese told his roommate, Norman: "People sure love arguing about their Top 1s. 'Oh, I want to handle Sirius one day, it has a rating of 2900!' Do you know what else has a rating higher than 2900? An MBT!"

"That's different, Reese. An MBT is a... tank. The Sirius is something you can hold and move. It's tactile," Norman replied.

"A howitzer, then. Tell me, what's the difference between a howitzer and the Sirius? The ammunition is the same!"

There never were any questions during readings—everyone knew better than to ask any. The instructor continued, "The sub-category, or the name, of a rifle is dictated by its core features; ammunition type, number of magnets, accelerating mechanism, et cetera. A 'Single' is a 2-or-4-magnet coil gun, and can be handled with one hand; a 'Swift' is a 6-or-8-magnet coil gun, and so forth. As such, the LRPN is informed by the sub-category, or the name, plus the revision number of that generation." She once again paused. "The letter following the rank states the acceleration mechanism: Ga-uss," she stressed the first syllable, "Co-il, Ra-il, and Ex-plosive. The final letter repeats the first letter of the name of the sub-category, so, for 'Swift,' it would be C-130RS."

"Have you seen a howitzer with a 'Breaker'?" Norman asked him.

"Have you seen any thousand plus rifles with

anything other than a ‘Chicane’? It’s all colon C, colon C, blah blah blah. Look at my C-29–something–RS colon C ‘Sirius,’ look at my C-20–something–RO colon C ‘Opulence,’” Reese reciprocated. “Howitzers!”

“The rapidfire piercer one also has a larpin’ number of thousand plus.”

Reese clicked his tongue. “Touche.”

Lying in bed with the lights off, Reese asked, “What’s even the point of ever bigger guns? A breaker ‘Swift’ still slices through tissue like a hot knife through butter.”

“I want to say... the impressive factor. Like, when I—there’s this innate desire to one-up others? Oh, that and shields.”

Great answer, Reese thought, *should be a public speaker some day.*

In Reveillane, he was staring at the goldplate under the “Mercy.” He scoffed.

Reese continued walking onwards, turning into the Maple cafe, seating himself next to the window pane wall; from the menu, he ordered a cappuccino along with a rice and smoked chicken bowl. He threw a glance around the contemporary-minimalist interior—boxy, panelled, neutral, and restrained. He reclined back, looking out towards the street, waiting; before his order arrived, his acquaintance, Liberty, walked in as per arrangement, and came over to his table.

“How’s it going?” Liberty opened, sitting down.

Reese shrugged it off, “Same old, same old. Is everything alright at Raymond?”

“Yeah, things are moving along splendidly—I really couldn’t ask for more. Gaia and Frazer are an amazing company; I finally submitted the layout for Roy.”

“Just about time.”

“Cheers to that—as long as it passes review and

we won't be caught torn between eleven concurrent projects, I'm happy," Liberty concluded.

The waiter came over; after a short period of contemplation, he ordered garlic chili prawns and a glass of watermelon lemonade.

As the waiter went away, Reese prompted him, "You sure have a taste."

"You keep saying that," he remarked, "I have always expressed that you only live once, might as well make the most of it."

After some talk and an ensuing pause between the two, Liberty resumed, "Is something bothering you, Reese? You're usually a lot more talkative."

"Could say that," Reese cut it.

"Someone at Revvy rubbed you the wrong way?"

Reese tacitly replied, "Them too... *they're* just reaching for the stars too hard."

"Well, it's not like they can achieve much otherwise, especially from where they're sitting. There is a balance to be struck, though, that's for sure."

"Yeah, that cornerpiece we're all missing. It is but a matter of time until they trip – that or someone makes them."

Liberty discarded, "They've been eyeing Blue Jays for a while now." *Practically everyone has*, he wanted to add.

"Yes, but now they have a plan," Reese asserted; Liberty perked up. "I don't know the details, but it sounds bogus and mighty eager to dress each one of us in an unholy wooden overcoat."

"Then why did you decline?" Liberty asked.

Reese did not reply.

Setting his arms on the table as support for his face, Liberty breathed in, then said, "I don't know the details,

but I'll tell you what: first of all, they will need the team alive for the op; second, I don't mean to pry, but isn't this what you came to Equinox for?"

Reese looked out through the window. Following preparatory birthday shopping for his mother, he was enthusiastically sharing the premise of triangulating the distance to distant objects, using the adjacent statue of Rutledge as an example. He was seven or eight years old at the time—he was fairly sure he was seven. God rays broke through downtown Raydeucar's jungle of towers, embellishing the avenue with vivid colors, the gentle wind rustling the grass, their surroundings unusually bright and joyous. His father began to frown, looking ahead. Reese looked at the source of irritation, witnessing an officer approaching their company, instinctively gulping, recalling all that he had learned of them.

Meeting him, the officer coldly requested, "Mr. Canmore?"

"Is something wrong, sir?" he politely inquired.

The officer commanded, "Follow us."

He beggingly prolonged, "I am with my son—"

The officer cut him short, gravely repeating, "Follow us."

He hesitated, delving into the cyberspace, "Give me a second, I'll call him a cab and—" as he was hit on the neural interface with the complex titanium barrel of a Caoz rifle, falling to the ground and cracking his skull against a cement planter of chrysanthemums, blood gushing; pronounced DOA when reaching medical.

Reese scoffed. He let out a long sigh. "Perhaps you're right, Liberty. My only hope is that the choice I will make will not be my undoing."

The waiter came back to their table with Reese's

cappuccino and rice and chicken.

Liberty remarked, “Well,” he looked at Reese. “And you say that ‘I sure have a taste’”

Reese chuckled.

“Reese, Elliot, May, please, take your seats,” the woman urged.

The trio seated themselves on the opposite side of the table.

It had been seven weeks since the plan had been put in motion—it has been almost twelve months since Reese accepted the position of 1st captain in Operation *Stargazing*. He was facing the mission lead, Cipher, who was settling in before beginning her reading of the finalized mission briefing. They were in a sealed-off room deep below Reveillane’s corpus. Though Equinox had many branches, Reveillane became increasingly boxed in over the past two months, due in no small part to Operation *Andromeda*, closely followed by *Pisces*.

“Let us begin,” Cipher opened, introducing everyone, “Reese, Elliot, May, right beside me is my assistant Erik; in the far corner is Sigun, our head link to Aurellise Desaux; Sigun, Erik, meet Mr. Canmore, the debut pilot, Ms. Schneider, the facility manager, and Mr. Murray, co-chief network engineer of this operation. The crew present here will be a key part of ensuring that the mission completes within the 12-minute timeframe of alarm to complete air dominance. The gist:” she turned to Sigun, “We barricade IF’s ‘Raydeucar Operational South Station’s’ underground and extract 28 Hover NAV-49’s via the rails.”

As Sigun wired up the neural interface, she continued, “For this mission, Equinox has sourced one quadmagnet C-783RF:B and six C-437GM:B, with ‘MAJT’-7 “Strides” complementing them.” *Just might be the way*

to party, Reese thought. “The ‘Fracture’ will be assigned to Fritz and planted by Wayne. The ‘Mercies’ will be distributed among six other distinguished ground assault members.”

Reese knew his part by heart: arrive at the OSS, descend to the garage, pilot a hover onto a “test flight,” let ground do their job while providing air support. The meeting, as the crew of three knew it, was merely formal. What concerned Reese far more was the discussion which continued throughout the last three reconnaissances: it was known that the Council tacitly deemed having increased IF presence at Raydeucar OWS—the north-western base, closer to the city—preferable. What was not known, however, was whether that applied only to the OWS, and not South as well. Consequently, that topic was not raised at any point during the meeting.

Having gone over the plan in detail, she concluded: “Soon,” she once again turned to Sigun, “Equinox will have 28 NAV-49 ‘Serendipities’ in its arsenal. Therefrom,” she momentarily paused, glancing around the room, “home run to stage two.”

At Raydeucar OSS, Reese exited the dressing room, running into a person blind. The woman he knocked over recognized him—so did he; helping her up, he parted from her, waiting for his fellow pilot before moving on a transfer to the Deep-Ground Hangar via ‘the pit’ platform elevator. Rummaging over the consequences of his acquaintance, he concluded: *this complicates things slightly*.

As the meeting concluded, Sigun remarked, pulling out, “Smooth as butter.”

“Brace for the worst but expect the best,” Cipher replied with a smile.

As they were heading down the hallway after

the debrief, May prompted Reese, “An enny for your thoughts?”

“They’re worth a couple more than that,” he returned.

“Would three make the cut, then?”

“Just about,” he smiled.

“Then spill it, mister.”

“OSS,” he murmured, throwing a glance at her. “To be perfectly clear, I am concerned more about there being more trouble below rather than above.” *A hover takes five minutes to prepare to go airborne from the rails. A rifle, he internally shrugged, not so much.*

“Huh,” May doubtfully acknowledged.

The conversation ceased as they ran by a member of the collective in the hallway.

Breaking the silence, May prompted, “Care for lunch?”

“Read my mind,” he replied. “How about the cafeteria?”

“We *have* one?” she stopped.

Watching Reese fill his dish, May asked, “Do you ever have anything other than chicken?”

“Occasionally. See, chicken is the perfect dish: it is by far the most environmentally friendly meat, it is difficult to mess up, and——easy protein.”

“Still, some people,” she elongated, “manage to make theirs taste like unseasoned rubber.”

“How did Tyson do that?” he inquired, reaching for the peas.

“Oh, it’s a list of prerequisites: you’re 14, you’ve never cooked anything before, you’ve heard chicken is a great food,” she dragged, staring at Reese, “and you boil it.”

“Oh, no. Make it rare at that point.” He threw a glance at her tray, “Frozen yoghurt?”

“Overheard some lady saying it’s the best thing they have.”

“Sheesh.” Not seeing a change of composure, he added under his breath, “Your funeral.”

Having sat down by the window—Reese with his grilled chicken with a side of roasted peas and a glass of orange juice, and May with her frozen yoghurt and fruits: cut melons, pineapples, and kiwis—Reese commented on the view of Brimbalt park from above, “Some say Revvy is the Experté of the Raydeucar’s Eastern belt.”

May threw a glance at the park, careful not to knock over the yoghurt. “I thought we had a neighboring competitor who took that role.”

“Palazza does not have that *je ne sais quoi* that Revvy and Experté have.” *Nothing commercial does.*

“You’ve been to Experté?”

“I’ve seen pictures,” Reese conceded. May smiled. “Mramor countertops, embedded gold enamel, not too bad for an antique building.”

“Theoderau Centrale is a beautiful place, but I’ve heard that locals prefer the outskirts more than the core of the island.” Throwing a glance around the cafeteria, she added, “Me? I would still go with the suicide island over the capital, let alone some metropolis on A-2.”

“I get the dislike for Theuneurau, but what makes the island special?”

“Has the best R&D I’ve seen in Thezeraine. Best school for special forces, too. So, you know, if you ever were to consider switching sides,” she laughed.

“I mean, that is what happens when there’s no bureaucracy,” Reese remarked.

“Why not opt for something like Atrials or some other all-forgotten city on D-2 then?”

“Last time I checked, only A-1 has free energy in the

air. 'Sparkles', or whatever they're called."

"I think it's 'sparkles'," she said. "We should deposit some on D-2 then."

"So much for Authern Vivae," he laughed.

May remarked, "This yoghurt is putrid."

"Told you," Reese taunted. May took another spoonful, shrinking back in regret. "Why would you do that?!"

Recovering, she said, "Just wanted to check whether it was as horrible as I caught it at first."

Reese paused, considering whether to make the remark. "You and Thezeraine both."

May giggled. "What's the prep for the counter punch, lieutenant?"

"No more meetings," Reese asserted. "No more meetings... Well, maybe one. I've a Longest Day festivity to attend."

"A gala? Who's the lucky girl?"

"Not a gala, you know I'm not up for that," Reese sighed. *Not again, not anymore.*

"Mix it up with a guy then?" May joked. Reese glared at her as though she slaughtered a child. *Apparently chicken isn't the only thing we have strong opinions about,* she thought as she reclined. "Bad joke."

"I just have an open-air rendezvous with Elliot." He clarified: "not like that."

The IT guy and a military guy. Quite a pairing, May thought. "Like a tryst?"

"A what?"

"A private reconnaissance, basically."

"Sure, a 'tryst,'" Reese settled.

"I was going to invite you to join us for overnight camping at Meridian, but it seems you have your plans for the evening sorted."

“That I do.”

As they were finishing their lunch, May remarked, “Seven eighty-three. The rating is a little high for a ‘Fracture,’ don’t you think?”

“A-B-C?” Reese discarded. A “carte blanche” (occasionally ciphered as “A-B-C”) is the codename of an alleged neural something thingymajig—similar to those of the old days—supplied to Equinox. In Reveillane’s underground halls, it is believed both Andromeda and Pisces were attempts to ascertain its existence and subsequently extract it.

“Thezeraine wants it, we have it,” she shrugged.

“According to urban legends spread by paranoiacs.”

“Then what’s the saving grace?” she posed, leaning in.

“I say there is none,” Reese gave up. “Divine wind or not, leaping into death’s lap should not be part of our calculus.”

The day had concluded—the evening was setting in. Reese threw a glance at the street through the window blinds, which, presently, was at a standstill—the rush hour traffic compounded with hectic last minute preparations for the Longest Day to render the outside seemingly frozen, and therefore lively with frustration. The halls of Equinox were of an equal composition, albeit as a result of a different kind of motivation. Even so, Reese found it mesmerizing to see everyone operating in tandem, each—much like a bee—somehow contributing to their own distinct goal to reach an overarching conclusion.

And if the lower floors of Equinox were indeed a hive, Cipher was, under the circumstances, its queen. Over the past 13 months, *Stargazing* has been progressively consuming her whole. In a desperate cry for fuzzy

emotions, she was swapping through printed photos, sitting back reclined in the chair of her office; her heels crossed on top of the mahogany desk. Restless nights poured into frustrating days, though she tried her best not to show it; her personal life, by now, was all but a faded memory. The worries of logistics, the uncertainty, and the end-of-day reliance on faith clasped her by the neck, swamping her life, plaguing her wherever she went, relentlessly and unceasingly.

"Come in," she responded to a slow, but sturdy knock.

Erik opened the door, entering in front of Dagner, a still-green recruit, who in turn was followed in by Guinevere, a senior logistics manager. Erik took the position by the door, and Dagner and Guinevere stood in front of the desk.

Having exchanged warm welcomes, Guinevere spoke on behalf of Dagner, "Sgt. Dagner proposes an armed suicide diversion in the city center 4 hours prior to the event, ma'am."

Cipher took time to sit up properly, thinking it over. She posed, "And we want to agitate Outpost Stations during critical hours because...?"

Erik replied, "Their idea is that it will give us the upperhand on two fronts: distance and readiness."

Cipher replied, "Picture this. We register IF activity and decide to investigate. In the process, we uncover a large-scale operation that will all but end us if successful." She leaned in, "Why should we prompt them to look closer?"

"Four hours isn't enough to reach conclusive evidence," Dagner interposed.

"Bullshit. I've seen successful solutions take off in two and a half hours. The alarm goes off and we're

toast,” Cipher replied.

Erik called Dagner out of the room, following him out.

“Then make it two,” Guinevere calmly proposed.

“Then they are agitated and brimming with energy,” Cipher discarded with audible frustration.

“Agitated where?” Guinevere returned. “Not at Southern!”

“At Western, then. We will have to secure the hovers, not just launch them!”

“Why would they even dig? They’ve been avoidant since *Pisces*!”

“If innocent people died as a result of *their* recklessness, everyone—us more than anyone—would be looking for answers!”

The screaming was faintly audible from the other side of the door. Dagner stood awkwardly by Erik, who was trying to shut his eyes.

“They’ve got lungs,” Dagner prompted.

“Be on edge and I’ll hear the capacity of yours,” Erik returned. “You with us, son?”

“Yep. Piloting.”

Erik nodded, “Thank you for your service.”

“I’m honored,” Dagner acknowledged.

They stood in silence until the yelling ceased in the room. Erik gestured to go back after a pause.

“... you just cannot deny the fact that this gives us a considerable advantage and that we should play this card,” they overheard as they entered the room.

Cipher raised her head, begging Erik with her eyes. He pursed his lips and nodded.

Cipher lowered her head. She shook it. “Alright. I’ll sign off on it.”

Guinevere smiled. As they exited, Erik remarked,

“Not the worst we’ve heard today.”

Cipher laughed, “Let’s rename ‘Equinox’ to ‘Solstice,’ Longest Day and all.” *Not in a million years would I come up with something dumber.*

Erik tuned in. “Ah. The golden age is truly upon us,” he said, heading out. With the door open, he added, “Because things turn gold when the sun sets on them.”

Give that one to the IC, they’ll rip it out of your hands and immediately run it by a live broadcast, she thought. She looked back at the worn printed photos, stashing them away.

“Dear Dagner,” Guinevere typed a few hours later, then got stuck. *Right, proposal accepted, arm with a Swift, three hours prior to. Ah, and mention the unfortunate soul.* She stared blankly at the display. *Now to put that into words...*, she concluded.

That, however, was behind, and the evening was ahead. As Reese was heading out for the day, Reuben held him up in the hall, asking him why he wasn’t on his feet as much as everyone else was—Reese replied, “And do what? I know you’d rather I be at my fullest tomorrow.” As he exited Revillane, he added under his nose, “My fullest does not arrive as a result of me overworking.”

The golden sun lapped the worn stone tiles on the edge of the street. Looking up, he saw the sun canvassing the clouds an iridescent peachy color. The already-lit lamp posts passed over his head, a tree occasionally propped up into view. The overhead garlands and flower barrels largely contributed to the sense of festivity, repeating it every year. The traffic on the street now poured in pulses, though Reese’s pace still surpassed it. He threw a glance over to a fountain pool next to a commercial center. Its soft, warm murmur, spelled out in conjunction with the gentle ambiance of street life,

reminded him of the cold water at a pool with which he was so frustrated with—years ago, on a day quite similar to this one. He also distinctly recalled a woman comparing the ice-cold water to melted milk, perhaps because he disagreed with the statement so much at the time. Forcefully blotting the memory out, he continued walking onward.

He arrived by Palazza with ten minutes to spare. He took a moment to examine the building, standing proud in stark contrast to the much more familiar, yet assuredly grim Reveillane. Palazza had a sleek, towering design, with smooth, rounded frames around its glass facades, highlighted by a marble and gold trim. The entrance was decorated with ornate flowers and white-blue buntings. An endless, continuous stream of people poured out of the building, meandering by the sunset-lit raised-bed gardens; all taking pictures, splashing the streets with friendly chatter. Reese was no man for parties: had he not been invited by Elliot to sub in for a drop-out acquaintance, he would not have given any attention to the Longest Day tradition, so fervently cherished by many as a symbolic testament to relentless human perseverance and the infallible promise of an upcoming better day. Though, knowing he had less time by the second, he warily stepped through the revolving doors.

Reese had not been inside of the building for years now—even so, he remembered the way to the elevator. Now, standing as a part of a group of people awaiting the elevator, he took a moment to denounce others' careless, yet admittedly cheerful faces. He happened to observe that his plain tee and khaki cargoes did not align with others' much more flamboyant dresscode, though he did not give the thought much energy. Squeezing into the crowded elevator, he stood collected, towering over the rest as the elevator stopped by floors on its way up.

Finally, it had reached the penthouse, where he was greeted by the restaurant's staff and invited to walk over to the Maître d'. Giving his name, he turned right and headed up a straight flight of carpented stairs, towards the roof.

As he approached the top, he felt the chilled conditioned air subside and be substituted by lukewarm and still city air. Finding it stifling, he walked over to the railing for a view of Raydeucar from above the top floor. Its evening skyline provoked in him a strand of intoxication: while the soft orange gradient of the sky, gradually rolling into pale blue, tinted the buildings in a serene peachy color, the countless windows, lit in the face of the evening, inspired a suffocating sense of humility and acted as a reminder of humanity's grandeur and our individual utter insignificance. To others, it would be a reminder of the grandness and vastness of human capability, which went hand-in-hand with the motif of the Longest Day—Reese would have been able to follow the same conviction, were he in any capacity to accept it. He stood motionless, appeasing himself with the evening view.

Someone patted him on the shoulder; he turned around to be greeted by Elliot with, "The man, the myth, the legend."

"Elliot," Reese opened, reaching for his hand; he turned his head to the woman accompanying him, and remarked, "you seem familiar."

"Paris," she answered, "we haven't been formally introduced."

"Pleasure. Where'd you lose the other one?" Reese asked them.

"Rossette dropped out last minute. I wonder why..." Elliot pondered to the company. "Shall we?" he pressed

on.

For its makeshift Longest Day banquet-space, Palazza had opted for a rustic aesthetic for its rooftop. The wooden floors, and tables, and earthy parasols played in-hand with the naturalisique backdrop of exotic plants and the Day's signature white-blue ribbons; yet he concluded the dining area was overly spacious, much like the city grid surrounding it. In spite of that, Reese appreciated the mounting height of the festoons, knowing he needn't worry of walking into them this year.

"It's nice," Paris blankly stated.

"Good thing the weather's nice, too," Elliot added.

"Oh yeah, *you* do not want rain right now," she added, gesturing towards everyone. Elliot rocked a white buttoned shirt—the upper two buttons were left unsecured—paired with office pants as his evening attire, and Paris was exhibiting a white blouse & palazzo pair, with an accent on her golden, sun-like necklace, smoothly contouring her collarbones with the fringe's tear-drop rays. Throwing a glance at each other's apparel, they both stared at Reese.

"*What?*" Reese said.

As they sat down and were handed the menus, Paris and Elliot periodically raised their eyes to take a look at Reese as they were browsing. He was seen flipping through pages; alas, unable to find his usual, he sighed. "So much for trysts," he said.

Elliot and Paris perked up, staring at Reese, mildly bewildered. Exchanging concerned glances with Paris, Elliot carefully prompted him, "You know what 'tryst' means, right?"

"Yeah, like, a private rendezvous," he discarded.

They sat in silence. Trying to hold back laughter,

Paris elaborated, “What do you think people do at a private rendezvous?”

Reese sat, contemplatively looking at the menu. “I don’t get it.” After a pause, he added, “Oh no.”

Paris and Elliot erupted with laughter. Reese tried to explain where he heard the word, but that only added to the guffaw. Trying his best to compose himself, Elliot desperately punched, “Well, si—since you couldn’t find it earlier, there actually is chicken on the menu. I think you should get some ‘*Coq au Vin*,’” squeezing the last part in a high-pitched voice.

“Bloody hell, Elliot,” Reese replied, laughing.

Once they received their orders, Elliot clarified, “When I said you should order it, I was joking.”

“No, it’s absolutely stellar. How’s the gra-a-a-cut-salmon-thing?” he asked Paris.

“Gravlux. I’ve had better,” she conceded.

“Do you think I can get the recipe?” Reese asked, gesturing at his bowl.

“Go for it,” Paris replied.

“I can give you my recipe,” Elliot said. “It’s not too hard to make, either.”

“I’m all for it.”

Elliot posted it to his Aurum inbox.

Paris left the party early. After the Solstice ceremony—per custom held at twilight—was concluded, Reese and Elliot lingered for a while longer on the rooftop. They leant against the railing, looking out towards the city center.

“Don’t see this every day,” Elliot said.

“I’ve seen better,” Reese replied. “Nothing compares to the view out of the cockpit after the rails. Speaking of—ready for tomorrow?”

Elliot held out a pause. “No. I don’t think anyone can

be ready for something like *Stargazing*.”

“As long as the ‘*Serendipities*’ are. I never asked, how did we bypass them?”

“Want the full version or the simplified one?”

“Not too into computers and security.”

Elliot began, “It’s update season. For security, you cannot overwrite the on-board software—that would end in a disaster. So the chip is soldered on, immutable, if you want to update to a new version you would need to solder the old one off, and the new one on. What we did is we injected some logic into the latest stable version to include a bypass that basically bricks most of its capabilities in the presence of a special key—it is a bit more complicated than that. Then, we soldered the new chips on while the birds were in maintenance in the DGH hangar. One by one. The most unnerving part was doing so without really knowing if they would actually work in the end.”

After the update jobs had concluded, he was summoned to supervise a NAV-49 as it prepared to go on “rails”—H’LaMDs (Hover’s Low-Altitude Mass Drivers), or “rails” as everyone referred to them, which functioned similarly to a rail-archetype Caoz rifle, using several rails to accelerate objects to hypersonic speeds using charge differences. Elliot’s heart was ramping up—his and everyone else’s thereby present in the “pit hangar.” The NAV-49 had gone onto the rails, and had the airlock close to depressurize.

“Moment of truth,” he overheard, as his eyes ran around the hangar; some thirty patched hovers, and all of that work hinged on this one being a success. He knew for certain that it should not break—then again, the most he could do was hope. He watched on a tablet as the acceleration had shot up, peaking at 6Gs of

acceleration, before being slammed back as it hit the air outside. Around ten seconds later, he heard the delayed crackle reverberate in the hangar. The pilot was told to engage the boosters and proceed with the standard benchmark. Elliot later got a sneak at the rapport for the test, where it was remarked that the Airborne Vehicle [AV] had become “snappier” and “more responsive.”

“I later got to check whether our key worked, on that very Hover, after it came down to the pit. I had to cover it with a reboot.” Elliot smiled.

“So, wait, how much gets cut?” Reese asked, worry echoing in his voice.

“You’ll have to rely on on-board sensors. No out-bound comms during.”

After a pause, Reese remarked, “You’re a good storyteller.”

“I’ve been told that,” he said, looking out towards the streets.

The two were standing in silence, out in a city slowly moving into hibernation.

“Reese?” Elliot prompted him. Reese listened in. “Have you ever felt like you don’t know what you’re doing?”

Reese smirked. “Like imposter syndrome?”

Elliot scoffed. “Worse.”

Reese’s smirk faded. He turned to the city. “Some times.”

“What do you do then?”

“I just... Push ahead, I mean, it’s never anything too serious, just do what you’re passionate about and you don’t have to worry,” he laughed off as a shiver ran down his spine. He threw a glance behind – it wasn’t there.

“Are you... Is everything alright?” Elliot asked, perplexed.

“Why wouldn’t I be?” he abruptly turned as he answered, suddenly distant.

“Uhm, nevermind that...” Elliot stuttered. “Just... promise to be safe?”

“When am I not?” Reese asked.

“Need a list?” Elliot smiled.

“No such thing exists. Unless you keep one.”

“Maybe I do, maybe I don’t,” Elliot said quietly.

Reese didn’t reply—after a bit, he said, “Want to call it a night?”

“Sure,” Elliot replied. “After you.”

By the time Reese got back to the street level, it was 11:30 PM. He opted for a tram to get back to his place in the dark. Before going lights out, he lingered a bit by the window, which oversaw the street from the fourth floor.

“What are you doing *here*, Reese,” he plainly asked himself, watching the neon lightstrips flicker. He pondered a little longer about where Elliot could have been headed. He texted him, asking if what he wanted to say was related to the birds. With that, he reached for his sleeping pills and took four—instead of the two he usually self-prescribed.

He nonetheless barely got eight hours of sleep. Another nightmare, *predictable, really*. As he was making coffee, he browsed through the notifications he received in the night.

“Cardinals? No,” he received from Elliot. He replied with a “k.”

His mornings have for the longest time been set in stone. Breakfast, exercise, shower, brush teeth, get dressed, out. In that sense, it would have been a late morning like any other—excusing the angst he discarded as “elevated heebie-jeebies.” Outside, he awaited a carpooled REF E. Service when he noted a crevice in the

asphalt of the sidewalk. It was but a few months ago when he sought shelter from a rampant storm, finding a pile of roof tiles lying by the entrance to his apartment building's ground floor. He remembered thinking: were he not held up—did he not arrive there five minutes later than planned, the spot now marked with a crack might have been the place of his undoing.

Despite Reese turning out to be an advocate for *Stargazing*, looking at the miniature ravine, in his disturbed mood he linked *Stargazing* with that fatal storm. Picturing: to the right of the crevice, his home; to the left, the rest of the world. Who, then, was under the debris, and was he the one to narrowly avoid it this time around? Torn out of his silent soliloquy by the rumbling of the arriving ESCab, he was seen jumping into the eight-seater. Looking out of the window as the vehicle set off, he made a verdict along the lines of how 'fragile' the balance of every world is.

"Raydeucar, in all its glory, is not a city which would have ever rallied under a unified banner—", Reese said at a pre-*Stargazing* debrief night in Reveillane's lower floors. The late evening debrief was arranged for two junior pilots, Solace and Beckett. Norman, his roommate from back in the day, and Liberty, the person Reese cited as the reason he picked up *Stargazing*—both close friends of Reese, were also present. "As of late, there is an exception: if you walk into a gin joint, and blast open with your resentment for the Thezeraine Imperial Council, every last glass in the room will go up. We all know how that came to be – over the last 70 years, the leadership of the Raydeucar Collective has built an 'antagonistic' relationship with the IC to whom they were—and are—directly beholden; which, blah blah, manifested in the events of the middle century. Off the top of my head, I can name all seven attempts to

de-escalate the conflict and each attempts' immediate telltale precursors, but I consider that a waste of time since, as we well know, all of them have failed. What we have at hand is but the ripened fruit of that failure to de-escalate: *Operation Stargazing*."

Going over the consequences of the mission, Norman asserted: "As Equinox, we know that if *Stargazing* succeeds, we needn't worry about the IC using the IF to 'figuratively' blow A-2 to shreds. For one, doing so would ruin the carefully orchestrated Lagrange gravarr." Beckett cracked up. "More importantly, though, the IC would have other, far more significant concerns if our ploy of power succeeds."

"What makes you think the REF won't put up a fight?" Solace asked.

"We are the REF," Beckett whispered.

"He's right, and it is not the REF we're worried about," Reese interposed. "In light of recent moves by Evenfall, IC brought forth the IF Special Forces Directorate to the OWS. What we do not know is whether the same will qualify for OSS, and if it does, that is a lot of trouble for us. One, they could shut down both bases to REF, and therefore us, killing off *Stargazing*. Yet even if the base is not shut down, the REF becomes unpredictable in the presence of the IFSF, and we do not want to see casualties among either."

"At the very least Operational West is... 260 kilometers north from the OSS," Norman added.

"Which is five minutes on a full-throttle NAV-49," Reese replied.

The mission was six hours out, and the trip to Raydeucar OSS would take three hours more. Though five associates have joined in, he opted to not engage in extensive discussions with anyone on the crew—

attributing that to not knowing anyone—going back to moodily looking out of the window every so often. The flying-by sparse yet impenetrable forests, sprawling on rigid mountainous hills, intermittent with riverside valleys, at times broken up by lone countryside manors intermittent between minor settlements, and other elements of the paysage worked hard to award a semblance of tranquility.

His peace abruptly dripped away as they drifted into the suburbs of Rivrett, a medium-sized city some fifty-to-sixty kilometers off the Raydeucar OSS. They voted for a 20-minute break, pulling into a charging station, as they awaited one final member to join their cruise. Getting out of the car to go into the station's shop, Reese noted another Service vehicle parked in the wild.

"They don't have chicken," May whispered to him as she walked past on her way to the check-out.

What?... "And a good afternoon to you too!" Reese clicked his tongue. *Wasn't planning on having anything to eat, anyway.*

He exited the place with a chocolate protein smoothie in his hand, or, as he affectionately referred to it, his "diabetes in a cup." May was not to be found, and the other Service vehicle had vanished. Minutes later, now with a fully packed vehicle, they set out to Raydeucar OSS; this time around, the scenery presented no reconciliation to Reese, who would favor clicking through all the possible routes of *Stargazing* evolving.

He cannot pinpoint the exact moment he realized he was in a dream; in any case, the contents of it were all too familiar by now. It was one of the few happy-ier memories of his childhood: he was at a bar, his father chatting with a coworker of his, the atmosphere malty and downtempoed, though bound to erupt with banter in the face of the night. The stark contrast between the

warm palette, created by the bronze sputnik's golden lights, blended with crimson and sapphire of neon, and the grim palette of the ever washed-out, pale, dark, and burnt Raydeucar of his childhood almost disturbed him now. He raised his eyes to meet a wall-mounted infotainment TV, tilted downwards, showing a replay of the boring daily news. He believes that he saw two men in mobile armor, fully enclosed, rocking the magnificent Caoz rifles—when one of them pushed a leisurely dressed woman back down into the sidewalk, where she and many others lay. Was she pushed, or hit, or shot? He might have cried out to his dad, hearing every aspect of conversation in muffled tones, as he – as his child self – tried to yell out at the top of his lungs, “WHY WOULD *THEY* DO SUCH A THING!?” The question reverberated in his head, amplifying in volume, superseding all other matters, building ever larger and grander, as the world broke apart into incomprehensible white noise.

Late that night, on the way to the bathroom, he overheard his parents speaking about the incident. His father, Conrad, told his wife, Valerie, about how strong Reese was at just five years of age. Reese giggled, and it was then that the grim reality crept in. He accepted the sharp crunch of a breaking cranium, and he knew of the terse, gory installation that would come before him now. He heard his mother scream; breathing in, and entered the kitchen. The room was blank, lacking furniture, but somehow excellently lit. He saw his father lying in a sea of his own blood. When he first started seeing this very dream, he believed it to be less callous than it is now. The creature of his father's corpse broke its neck to stare him down with its unwavering sight. The corpse rose to his height in eerie, convulsion-like, pulsing motions, its bones dislocating and popping back into place. Reese was petrified, and knew the creature was

aware of his fear, but he still pretended he could feign indifference. Staring him down, the creature began lightly, but increasingly rapidly and firmly hitting him on the shoulder, creaking at him, gushing blood out of its mouth.

He woke up in cold sweat to being nudged on the shoulder to get out of the Service to pass the Raydeucar OSS's checkpoint. Clocking in from slumber, he gawkily emerged from the car onto the roundabout, heading for the underground Checkpoint-2 for personnel. He did not remember feeling sleepy or dozing off; though, he resolved to blot out the dream out of his mind. Having slotted in his ID card, he underwent visual ID under the cordial scrutiny of REF security officers. Passing through security with zero issues, he walked along a prolonged tunnel, arriving at a staircase, which he preferred over the elevator.

The staircase led directly onto the curled roundabout Arrivals-2's platform. Between the three Arrivals areas, this one was the most astute and barebone. The only points of interest in its immediate proximity were the WC and the low-rise roundabout garden. Reese's ultimate destination at Raydeucar OSS was its famous deep-ground hangar at Sector-4, built for cutting-edge deployments and tests, mostly centered around its NAV-type Hovers, for which it had three pairs of H'LaMDs. Before that, he would need to stop by the Sector-4's barracks, for which a mini-shuttle was departing with one remaining seat.

"How was Meridian?" Reese prompted May, who opted to sit next to Reuben Allitt, the person to bring the second hover into the air.

"I was hoping to see you there," someone interposed in front of him. Reese turned his head, noticing Norman and Liberty.

Liberty picked up, "The sight was truly something to behold: we were on a meadow bench overlooking a descending mountainous taiga;" adding gestures into his speech, he fervently continued, "which opened to the valley, dimly illuminated by the stars of the midnight-blue sky, interlocked by two low mountain ranges coming together to form an alpine basin. The outline of the shimmer probed in——"

"That's it, you're losing talking privileges," Norman interrupted.

Reese laughed.

"I doth receive thine remark with an avidly aching heart," Liberty retorted with a smile.

"No-o-o-o-pe," Norman stretched, shaking his head.

"The air was really nice," May said to Reese, whom she noticed to be visibly distraught. "Slept like babies."

"My evening at Palazza was not half bad either," Reese remarked. Remembering a matter of yesterday, he prompted, "Say, do you know what 'tryst' means?"

"Told you, 'a private rendez-vous,'" she replied.

Liberty broke off his discussion with Norman to assert: "You *didn't*."

"Did what?" Norman asked.

Reese paused, picking words. "I'm gonna get my revenge."

"Oh-ho-ho," Liberty scoffed, turning to whisper into Norman's ear.

May tried to hold back a smile, "Not a clue what you're talking about." *Besides, Elliot needs all the help he can get.*

After discussing the "'tryst' incident," as they collectively referred to it, at length, their discussion was brought to an abrupt close at Reuben shushing all of them to listen in: radios in the front chirping about an

“act of terrorism” in Raydeucar.

“Eleven IFSF injured, two of those dead,” someone pronounced at the front of the mini-bus.

“Injured how? What’s their status?”

“Was it a targeted attack?” Norman tuned in.

“CC-11.1&6. Breakers. Possibly Equinox...?” the officer at the front returned.

Caoz rifle, injured with breakers and then the rifle was overcooked, Reese internally translated.

“Motive, organization known?”

“So far single instance, true motive unknown at this time.”

Reese sat back, returning to prognosing once more. *The good news is, if IFSF was on-ground, serious measurements would have already been imposed... Surely this... can’t be us, we wouldn’t sabotage Stargazing... unless?... He turned to May for an answer; glancing into her eyes, he could ascertain a conclusive verdict about the situation at hand. What if it had taken me fifteen seconds to realize something that needs to go unnoticed for 150 more minutes?*

Upon arrival at Sector-4’s “barracks,” the group split up without a word, now abiding by their over-rehearsed playbook. Passing security, Reuben closely trailed Reese, who was blazing through the rejuvenated and overly-sprightly halls. Since his arrival, the atmosphere had palpably shifted from routine dullness to active tension, which he knew to arise less from anxiety and more from a mix-up in routine. They arrived at the flight quarters; Reese redressed into his Avnex flight suit equipped with a 3-piece nitritol-powered Aegis ‘AIMS’-3 “Service” package, featuring a locked PHm portable shield and cuttingedge momentum modulators through induction. He slotted in a 33g Nitritol battery, armed himself with

a C-131CS:N “Single,” and confidently blew the door into the hallway open, knocking over a woman who ran on the side.

Helping her up, Reese recognized in her Vesper Retague, an IFSFD representative, immediately stepping back and rendering a salute; she dismissed it. “Lt. Canmore, I was looking for you. Do you know where Lt. Allitt is?”

“Yes, Ma’am. Lt. Allitt is getting dressed, Ma’am.”

“Head to the DGH in his company and recon there, the flight is not off but its premise might change.”

“Understood, Ma’am!”

The IFSF is on premise—Reese reasoned that this is likely a recent turn of events. As he stood waiting for Reuben, he grasped with the fact that the latest piece of intel might have doomed all of them. Once Reuben was out, Reese gestured to follow him to the “pit,” whispering: “IFSF.” Reuben rolled his eyes, but did not show any exasperation beyond that. Walking down to the shuttle station to transfer to the DGH he reckoned: *was it Equinox, or was it not... If it was, this is either a genius ploy or an idiotic blunder... Oh, for all that is sacred, this complicates things slightly.*

Riding to the hangar in silence, he in turn observed that his environment was growing increasingly quiet. He got chills, seeing REF corps grow distant. Thuds—repetitive thuds, and the tungsten scent of blood. *You’re dead, so stop trying, he told off internally.* He tried to disappear in the crowd, but knew he had no place to hide. He felt like everyone was staring him down. *What are you doing here, Reese?* He breathed in with a resolution, *I just need to get to the Hover.*

He stepped out of the shuttle and made his way to the open gate of the large platform elevator. It hosted

several fixed crate pallets and around thirty people bound for the underground facility. Reese walked over to the center of the platform, eyeing Retague as she orchestrated the processions for descent. All the while, he stared at the angled ceiling before him, cutting down at a roughly 30° slope, embellished with altitude markers and structural protrusions, with large pipes running along the canals in them. The gate behind him lowered, then locked. The platform dropped, slowly accelerating downwards. Everyone took their positions, standing out—Vesper stood in front of him. The platform reached its maximum velocity, and would, at this rate, reach the DGH in approximately six minutes. Reese closed his eyes, listening to the creaking of machinery.

Reuben and himself continued standing upright, as the rest tripped forward by the elevator platform tripping to a sudden halt. The lights went out, and Reese instinctively reached for his holster. *Is this outage intentional?* If it is, by hesitating right now, he is trading out an upperhand. If it isn't, if even a single Equinox member falters, the mission comes down to heavy improvisation. But if it is... he would have to wait for the sound of gunshots to confirm so. He lit up his 'AIMS' shields, painting the platform in a dim green hue, taking his hand off his hip. In the meantime, one by one, everyone on the platform recovered to their feet sans major injuries.

"You owe me twenty," he overheard someone whispering.

"Double or nothing, it doesn't do that again," someone replied.

"You're on!" the first guy pronounced with enthusiasm.

IF's finest, Reese thought... *I'd be so in.*

Mallory and Norman stood in a dark vertical elevator by themselves; Norman was holding a portable casing for prototype rifles, the C-783RF:B “Fracture” inside it. The C-437GM:B “Mercies,” masked as high-end C-422RP:B “Powers” had already been handed off to designated Equinox security corps.

Mallory coughed. “I hate rotating shifts,” he said.

“Why?” Norman asked.

“They suck.”

“Fair point.”

Half an hour after the power came back on, Norman caught up with Reese in the DGH’s Hangar zone, retelling him the story.

“Did you laugh?”

“No.”

“Good.”

Reese saw Elliot by the H’LaMD panel, deciding not to glance in that direction again.

“Alright,” Norman started. “Status for rails?”

“Positive, actually,” he replied, giving a glance backwards. “Had a meeting with Vesper, the current flight plan is to proceed as planned, but be on the ready for expansive strategies.” He glanced at Norman, who appeared to be a bit shellshocked.

“Retague?” He asked.

Reese nodded. “We’ll see her soon.”

“Lovely.”

They walked across the hangar in silence. “Do we know if it was Equinox?” Though, what Reese wanted to ask was, do they know that it was Equinox.

“It being a crazed civilian is what all the latest gossip points to,” Norman hung in the air.

Well, I’ll let you find it out yourself, Reese concluded.

On this evening, the hangar was fairly crowded by

airspace standards; a congregation of technicians and other members crawling around the frightsome jets, pumping in nitritol-v11 into the high-set sweptback delta wings, which terminated in split-tip winglets, verifying rapid interior repressurization, and testing underside hover platforms as well as the rear-end nitritol transformers wired up to the jets. Throughout his career of piloting the NAV-49, Reese came to be an expert in its construction, its capabilities, and its worst weak-points.

“What’s the hardest thing about piloting a Hover?” a date of his once asked him.

“Uh, I would say... Trusting that the machine will do exactly what you need to do,” he replied from across the table. Elaborating, “I’m simplifying, but the core engine’s performance highly depends on the amount of air you can compress into it, meaning the faster you go, the better it behaves, roughly speaking. It takes a long time to build that confidence, and some people chicken out because Hypersonic-5 is too fast, even with the comfort of the Aegis managing acceleration heebie-jeebies.”

She smiled.

Taking his time in browsing through the preliminary flight plan for Hover 7921, Reese took notice of an op-ready load-out—missiles, most of all. *Bye-bye Revvy*, he giggled to himself, distraught. The forecast revealed that the sky would be partially cloudy, with the afternoon sun gleaming—no signs of rain or precursor for strong wind: minus the updrafts, ideal flight conditions. He typed in the test procedures into the plan with great detail, submitting it. Satisfied, he looked around, nodding to Reuben, similarly preparing for takeoff; then, he went to board the 7921 Hover NAV-49 “Serendipity.”

Sitting down, his body and neck were belted in by a mechanic. He put on the helmet and wired up to the neural port—the whole machine feeling like an extension of his body—running final pre-flight checks. OK, OK, OK, OK, *full nitritol tanker...* “All systems online, give go ahead for take-off via H’LaMD-1 from the OSS DGH-4.”

The small pushback car rotated him around to face the rails. Giving low power to the jets, he slowly rolled towards the entrance of the H’LaMD. He slid the Hover into the airlock, the landing gear folding in, magnets pulling the Hover into the main tunnel, the airlock closing behind. After sliding horizontally for a few seconds, the Hover came to a halt. The airlock tilted plus 70 degrees pitch-wise, letting the Hover gently slide back and rest at the bottom of the rails. The rails lit up.

“H’LaMDs unlocked, takeoff granted for H-7921, Avec Noi,” he received over the radio.

“Avec Noi,” he repeated – Avec Noi was a Thezerainian “good luck” with an acknowledgement of its inevitability as a result of the person’s talent – then, he powered the Aegis SAS, flipping switches on the dashboard, putting on the airmask, priming the rails. He breathed in. “Takeoff protocol initiated, power on.”

He stared at the seemingly endless tunnel of the rails, carrying the outline of the Hover *ad infinitum*, when he felt a drastic shove upwards. In moments, the separate lit frames pulled together into a continuous blur of strobing lights, the Hover rumbling the entire kilometers-long structure. The vacuum of the H’LaMD tunnel cut off. The Hover slammed into surface air, producing a deafeningly loud supersonic crackle, quickly gaining altitude as it dragged the mach-cone to the skies. The hover blew past the clouds, and Reese started inching it downwards to slow the altitude gain

on his way to operational height. He throttled up the engine and engaged it, supplanting the wavering initial momentum boost from the H'LaMD. He leveled the Hover off at 22 degrees of gain, overjoyed to be in the air. The magnum lazure skies unabatedly greeted their king.

"Continue altitude gain until 16 thousand meters," he received.

"Copy."

The rumble of the second Hover accelerating on the rails reverberated through the DGH—the hangar astir to get the third one in the air. Thus, *Stargazing* was put into motion. Everyone on the crew watched the third Hover go into the airlock. Norman had turned the briefcase with the Fracture towards himself, ready to open it. He glanced at Elliot, who had recently arrived.

An alarm blared, repeating: "Warning, dysfunctional Hover on H'LaMD-1. H'LaMD-1 power off."

The impaired animal slotted in the card now!? Elliot realized. *Well, we had to start it somehow.* He pinged May, requesting facility override and issued a drop in power, initiating *Stargazing*.

The alarm ceased. After a click, the PA pronounced, "Initiate S-Z."

In a matter of seconds, all communications went down. Both airborne Hovers had gone offline. Equinox security corps with fully-ablaze Aegis 'MAJT'-7s ran out, screaming while urging cooperation, no shoot-out on the horizon. Norman pulled out the heavy C-783RF:B "Fracture" from the casing, slotted in the J-magazine and the n'n'a bridge, wired it to his neural port, and engaged his 7-part shields. The underground facility once again rumbled, as the third hover had gone into the air.

Seeing soldiers run out, shouting, a facility engineer quickly slipped out of the hangar into the adjacent living quarters, and started breaking it for the elevators. He ran into a group of alert IF security personnel, who prompted him on the situation.

“I don’t know! Comms went down——then security started running with dynamic Aegis and what looked like Powers!”

“Why?”

“I don’t know! Some kind of incident here?”

The IF soldiers glanced between each other, priming their rifles and running towards the hangar.

“On the floor, hands behind your head!” Norman yelled to Retague, aiming a primed Fracture at her back.

“This is idiotic,” she voiced, complying.

Norman momentarily turned his head to see IF soldiers run out and engage fire with piercers. He saw sparks flying as their piercers grazed their ‘MAJT’-7s, seeing an engineering staff member twitch and collapse.

He turned back to Retague, who took the opportunity to swivel around, shields engaged. He squeezed the trigger of the “Fracture” for a split second; his hand corrected the aim of the barrel, and a continuous, amplifying, devilishly loud sequence of whiplashes fired, echoing throughout the facility, overloading the Aegis panel as it ruptured into thousands of sparks, Retague dropping to the floor in discontinuous parts. Norman spun around to face the hangar, a piercer grazing the PHm panels of his shields, his adrenaline spiking, aiming the “Fracture” and cutting through military ‘AIMS’ shields like a fire through the woods, hands shaking, but not missing a single shot. The two officers in pieces, he and others held fire.

“Fracture! They have a Fracture!” someone yelled as

the scene collapsed into silence.

Norman looked down at the “Fracture,” grinning, then headed for the living quarters, his rifle boiling off cryogenic coolant as others jumped back to power the Hovers.

Hearing the shots in the hangar, the REF engineer gulped, making the turn for the elevators out of the DGH. He ran to the nearest one and punched the up arrow. Neither this one, or the next, or the next responded to his frenzied mashing. Five of his fellows from the shift ran in, similarly bound for disappointment.

“Do they work?” someone asked.

“Powered off, it seems.”

“What do we do?”

At that moment, more gunshots intermittent with supersonic whiplashes broke out somewhere in the hallways; everyone covered their ears. The engineer moved his head and spun his elbows, gesturing: “We need to go.”

The shots passed as abruptly as they started. The facility rumbled.

Reese leveled off the Hover at operating altitude, rolling it left and pitching it up to initiate a U-turn, cruising over the airspace of Raydeucar OSS. He saw the fourth NAV-49 get picked up by the fire-control radar. He gave out a sigh of relief.

As the fifth Hover went up, his radio clicked, “Canmore, add 63 degrees yaw and hold.”

“Affirm.”

Well that's one way to order airspace expansion. Reese softly pivoted the Hovercraft to the right. He checked for POIs over the map, presuming he would be heading for Raydeucar. He was understeering for it. He double checked his addition with the navball. He stared at the

map, noting another Equinox hovercraft following his change in trajectory.

He received, "Ramp from SS to SS-5. Fritz is your wingman"

Why is hypersonic necessary?... The OWS, we just aren't dead-on. "Affirm." He moved the throttle lever to its upper limit.

He sat back, feeling a spike in G-Force and the increased drag. The backside of the aircraft became enveloped in a sonic cone, slowly expanding with greater speeds; the whir of the engines now supplanted by the airbreaking of the sonicboom. His radar picked up a reading, coming from the OWS.

"Incoming signature at 290," Reese issued over the radio.

"Copy, ramping down," Reuben acknowledged.

Being within range of the OWS, Reese followed Reuben in dropping to SS-1.5 speeds. He turned the Hover to face the signature head-on, mirroring his intentions over the radio. The two hovers aligned in a striking formation; Reuben lagging behind Reese's right-hand wing. He stared forward, noticing a black dot, slowly becoming more prominent, right until a Hovercraft blew over the duo's heads.

From the split second he caught of its silhouette, Reese identified it as a NAV-63. He aggressively flipped the Hover on its rear and jacked the yaw to the maximum. Reese knew Reuben would have mirrored him. Midway through the 180°, he paused his gain before picking it back up. Completing the maneuver, he fired up the engines, quickly moving over to the NAV-63, which appeared to be trying to get Reuben painted. Pirouetting through the air, the trio followed each other, trying to avoid getting painted.

“Reese, where are you right now!” Reuben came in.

“Just another 20 seconds,” Reese replied calmly as he threw the Hover into another maneuver.

“I would be doing way more if we were swapped!” Reuben yelled, thrusting the Hover up once again, as a continuous high-pitched beep from the RWR went on in the cabin. The tone blared up a tone, and Reuben engaged the flares and catapulted the Hover upwards in an evasive maneuver. “Reese!”

“Oh, he’s dead now!” Reese reacted. As he closed in, the enemy hovercraft began swiveling around, avoiding the lock. The moment the crosshair snapped onto the NAV-63, Reese yelled, “F-3!” and ordered a radar-guided strike.

The NAV-63 threw out chaff, but could not avoid the creeping missile. It crept up to the delta wing and blew, sending the NAV-63 into a downward spiral. “One down!” Reese exclaimed frantically. “Where’s my thank you?”

Reuben did not reply.

“Alright, Hover-Over OWS,” Reese issued.

He evened out the Hover at operational height. The two hovercraft cruised at altitude, and within minutes, they were on the verge of Raydeucar OWS’s airspace.

A column of light tore through the left wing of Reese’s hovercraft, snapping it off, his neural connection coming offline. The NAV-49 immediately dove into a deadly spin, Reese’s helmet bashing into the side of the cockpit, the console vocalizing: “Bank angle! Bank angle! Pull up! Engine fire left/right! Pull up! Engine out...”

His head rang; with all his strength, he reached to clasp onto the ejection lever. The console continued blaring: “Bank angle! Flight controls! Eject!” Fighting

for his life, he clasped onto the lever, but could not pull it down. *It's supposed to be easy!* The blare continued, mixing together “Altitude!” and “Terrain ahead!” He pulled down on the lever with all his might, breaking it off. The hover spun closer towards the ground, quickly zeroing in. The top of the cockpit blew open, and he was thrown out of the Hovercraft towards the ground, axially spinning in the seat. As the parachute opened and Reese was swung towards the earth, the air displaced by the carcass of the Hover wobbled the parachute, making it unable to lose precious velocity. Though the parachute would not tear, his descent remained rapid enough for the snapshot of the forest, milliseconds before impact, to be the last thing he could remember.



§ Into The Dark

Her head felt like it would explode. Grunting, she drew her hand across the ground, the texture of which felt unusually stiff yet crystal-like; cold. She opened her eyes, surveying the iridescent wireframe, lightly pulsing through vieuxtritol hues. The ground appeared to be composed of an assortment of semitranslucent cuboids, shimmering, with blue at its baseline. Before her she saw an infinite, blank horizon.

She quickly sat up, looking around the platform, her headache vaporizing. She looked down at her hands, a collection of levitating blue dots, leaving fading trails upon movement. She looked around.

This doesn't seem to be real, she posed at her surroundings.

At a small Celebration of Life held in her honor, the eulogy she kept in her drawer was recited amidst her closest friends. It terminated in the following four lines, read aloud:

“And not until the *evening notes of subtle afternoons*
When agony unfolds *triumphant* ornamental sutures
The *weight* emotion places *does* one heed; *typhoons*
Ravaging peoples’ past, *and soon* – their *futures*.”

The atmosphere within the circle was quite somber. Wax candles were set around her portrait. The person reading the eulogy set it down on the memorial table, sitting down with everyone else. In the ensuing silence, one member of the group asked, “Why do we even do

this?”

“Because that’s who we are.”

She sat against an elevated platform in this place she started calling “The Limbo.”

“You know,” she said out loud to the empty space, “when I pictured eternal stillness, I did not picture this.”

No reply came.

“But of course...” she hung in the still air, with a degree of disappointment.

Some time later, she clicked her tongue. “This is hell.”

She looked around, seeing a widening white crevice in the platform. Walking over to it, she looked into it, but only saw a white void. She hesitated. Thinking it over, she kept retreating from the expanding ravine. Shrugging, she dived into it.

She felt a strong shock in her neck area, as she fell forwards from the wall onto the metallic floor of the dark room, producing a loud thump, echoing through adjacent hallways.

In the circle, a person critiqued the reply, “Who ‘we are’?”

“Yep...” they replied with a hopeful glance. “Nous sommes Apex, the ones who blindly go *into the dark*.”

III. You Know My Name

set in Theoderau, coming 2027